

WEEK 5 · INNOCENCE

CLASS 2

What Innocence Does

READING 1

A World without Innocence – Ticktin

READING 2

“Tender Angels, Insensate Pickaninnies” in *Racial Innocence* –
Bernstein
(optional)

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A world without innocence

ABSTRACT

What exactly *is* innocence—why are we morally compelled by it? Classic figures of innocence—the child, the refugee, the trafficked victim, and the animal—have come to occupy our political imagination, often aided by the important role of humanitarianism in political life. My goal is to see how innocence, a key ethico-moral concept, has come to structure what we think of as politics in the contemporary Euro-American context—how it maps political possibilities as well as impossibilities. The centrality of innocence to the political imagination is shaped by a search for a space of purity, one that constantly displaces politics to the limit of innocence and thereby renders invisible the structural and historical causes of inequality. We need, then, to open up political, moral, and affective grammars beyond innocence. [*morality, humanitarianism, purity, suffering, political imagination, secular liberalism, contamination*]

The now-famous image of Alan Kurdi, the three-year-old Syrian boy whose body washed up onto a Turkish beach in September 2015, grabbed the world's attention, eliciting sympathy rather than the usual mix of fear and indifference toward those who have left their homes to land on European shores. The photo gave the "refugee crisis" a new face: innocence.

There is perhaps no more essential image of innocence than that of a child. Humanitarian organizations regularly figure children on their home pages and in fundraising materials, to elicit support for those considered most vulnerable. And even in this increasingly illiberal era, images of children are powerful: in April 2017, when Syrian leader Bashar al-Assad attacked his own people with chemical weapons, US president Donald Trump said in response, "It crossed a lot of lines for me. When you kill innocent children, innocent babies, babies, little babies, with a chemical gas that is so lethal—people were shocked to hear what gas it was" (Borger, Smith, and Rankin 2017).

But some images of children are considered more heartrending than others. Why did Alan catch the world's attention? Since then, many children's bodies have washed up on the shores of Europe, with little response. Why did the images of Syrian children touch Trump, while those of injured Mexican children do not? The point, of course, is that only some people and some plights get noticed when innocence is what draws our attention to them. Furthermore, while innocence can compel responses to important events such as the refugee crisis or the war in Syria, it can also create a distinction between worthy and unworthy victims in these same events. While many say the photo of Alan Kurdi is what finally shamed Europe into action, ideas and images of innocence—and the moral imperative they engender—have a long history of actually hurting those they intend to help.

We need to understand the concept of innocence: its historical and philosophical groundings, and how it functions as a political, not simply a moral, concept. What exactly *is* innocence—why are we morally compelled by it? What gives it its power? My goal is to see how such moral and ethical terms come to structure what we think of as politics, and what we can do, think, and feel—how they map political possibilities as well as impossibilities.

Far from being understood as an engagement with the regular stuff of politics, like power or the organization of collective life, innocence is defined as freedom from both the worldly and unworldly.

According to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, *innocence* means “freedom from sin, guilt or moral wrong in general”; “freedom from specific guilt”; “freedom from cunning or artifice.”¹ This space of “freedom *from*”—this negative freedom—is so free indeed that it is seemingly free of content; it purports to be a state of *moral and epistemic purity*. Innocence is defined as a state of guilelessness, artlessness, want of knowledge or sense—in the terms of the *OED*, it is a state of ignorance, even a state of “silliness.” In this sense, innocence is perhaps as far from politics as we could possibly imagine. But innocence is a concept that—either because of or despite its very emptiness—has been deployed politically in more or less vigorous ways over time; indeed, it has moved into the center of political life today.

In the contemporary era, we are embroiled in a search for a space of purity, a space outside corruption and contamination, a space emptied of the power that can ground both tolerance and action; innocence provides us with such a conceptual space. Yet, because innocence is both mythical and ephemeral, we are constantly displacing politics to the limit of innocence in a never-ending quest, and in the process the structural and historical causes of inequality get rendered invisible. In the search for purity, a very particular politics gets produced, and another, disabled. To this end, we need to open up political, moral, and affective grammars beyond innocence. Ultimately, I do this to clear the way for alternative ontological starting points. What would a world look like without innocence?

While innocence is a concept with a vast range and history, I focus on its ethico-moral dimensions in the Euro-American context after the 1960s. This means, first, that I locate innocence in a particular secular, liberal world that is concerned with individual autonomy, freedom, and rationality, as well as with the limits of humanity, of which equality and dignity are key principles. Innocence helps define these principles, sometimes as their constituent outside, sometimes as their precursor, and often as their hope for the future. Innocence, however, has persisting Judeo-Christian contours that give it power even in worlds that may border on illiberal or authoritarian. Even in the more illiberal political regimes that hold sway from the United States to Turkey, where principles of democracy, individual freedom, universal equality, and religious toleration may no longer hold a central place, moral principles such as humanity and innocence still play an important role, albeit with differing interpretations and responses. For instance, Trump denounced the chemical attacks in Syria as “an affront to humanity” and subsequently launched direct strikes against the Syrian people. Similarly, the unborn fetus plays an enormously important role in right-wing political agendas globally as the ultimate example of purity and innocence. Of course, liberalism and authoritarianism need not be mutually exclusive (Mahmood 2015); seeing innocence across these realms may actually provide insight into the nature of

liberalism. In this sense, while some say this is not the time to critique liberal values, I find it as important as ever to trace how innocence gets deployed politically and to open up space for alternative ways of thinking.

Second, I will not deal centrally with innocence in its arguably most recognizable guise—that is, as a legal or juridical concept. Of course, early appearances of the concept define innocence as free not only from knowledge but also from specific wrong or guilt.² In contemporary legal terms, innocence is about acquittal—a decision to acquit means that the judge or jury had a reasonable doubt as to the defendant’s guilt. It may be based on exculpatory evidence or a lack of evidence to prove guilt. It does not mean that there is absolute certainty, only reasonable doubt. To find someone innocent is not necessarily to make a judgment on who they are but on whether they committed a particular act. In other words, the legal concept has developed to judge acts, not identities (although, as Janet Halley [1993] has demonstrated, acts and identities may not be as easily distinguished as we might think). The legal concept leaves room for uncertainty; it does not presume absolute truth. This is not the case with innocence as an ethico-moral concept, which is much less flexible, much less compromising, and which helps to constitute identities or kinds in relation to purity. While these different registers certainly work together to determine its meaning, it is the ethico-moral register that has been activated in more politically salient ways, and so I limit my discussion to that.

Histories of innocence, configurations of purity

Innocence promises a space of purity. This promise is also innocence’s political potential—in other words, its potential to engage with the power relations of the dominant order and the shape of collective life by defining their outer limits. Innocence comes into being in relation to its various binary others, such as guilt, knowledge, and sexuality. While the concept does different work in relation to these binaries, in each case innocence works to regulate a space of purity: sometimes this means to be without knowledge, sometimes to be without intention, sometimes to be free from desire, and sometimes free from guilt. It works as a boundary concept, and in the process it helps produce and regulate human kinds and their constituent outsides—it helps to imagine “humanity.” The counterintuitive aspects of the concept are important in this regard. For instance, while the Latin etymology of *innocence* focuses on harm (*in-* + *nocens*, “not harmful,” which is clearly a central feature of the concept), the etymology of *in-* + *noscere*, “not to know,” is perhaps even more significant. What does it mean not simply to be empty of knowledge, but specifically to *not know*?

Innocence comes into view early in relation to its theological interpretations. These locate innocence in the story of Adam and Eve, wherein innocence means not

knowing the difference between good and evil; it means lacking worldly knowledge. Innocence is represented as a state of calm and repose, particularly in the Garden of Eden, before the fall of humanity, when Eve eats from the tree of knowledge. The Fall helps to define humanity afterward; the loss of innocence is *how* we become human. In this sense, as philosopher Joanne Faulkner (2008) points out, innocence is inherently unsustainable, overdetermined by its conceptual history within Christian discourse: it is a mythical state, destined to be toppled by humanity. Innocence also implies a lack of responsibility, insofar as innocent life is bound by a divine authority, and the Fall brings to human life a will and responsibility of its own.

This Judeo-Christian history continues to resonate and shape our ideas of innocence, even as it gets used to different ends. Recalling the Garden of Eden, Enlightenment thinkers such as Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1987a, 1987b) also imagined a time of innocence that preceded the social contract and the political life of citizens; for Rousseau, innocence is exemplified in the state of nature and conceived of as “oneness with nature.” Again, it is understood as a state of unsullied simplicity, where human and animal are not clearly distinguishable. As with the Garden of Eden, the departure from the state of nature is the beginning of our social existence, our start as political animals.

Central to this philosophical history is epistemic or experiential purity: the absence of knowledge or experience, or sometimes even the active repelling of it. Such purity structures moral categories, filling out binary notions of deserving and undeserving, the innocent and the guilty, ultimately giving shape to different human kinds. Of interest is how innocence is constantly deployed to *produce* this economy of knowledge, action, and purity—how it regulates what counts as knowledge and what is understood as purity, and for whom. Innocence has worked to produce the idea of a deserving humanity, one that can escape the compromised and often-corrupt nature of political life. In marking off a period of epistemic and moral purity, the concept of innocence has produced worthiness, but only insofar as it is also a space of freedom from desire, will, or agency. While literary theorist James Kincaid (1998, 16) suggests that the empty figure of the innocent allows the admirer to read just about anything into its vacancy, my goal here is to qualify this negative state—that which is lacking. Sometimes the missing element is attached to desire—it leaves the subject as asexual; sometimes it means lack of will or intention. Almost always, however, the lack leaves one incapable of being a thinking, engaged, active, or informed subject. In valorizing purity, innocence has also produced humanity as a population of unknowing dupes. While it is not my goal to recuperate a normative liberal idea of humanity as composed of rational, autonomous, agentive beings, I do want to mark this as the opposite of such a normative humanity, one that leaves no space for other ways of being in the

world. That is, innocence acts as the boundary for liberal ideas of personhood, where this constituent outside is simultaneously idealized and denigrated.

Take the archetypal figure of innocence: the child. Capturing innocence in the figure of the child reflects this search for purity in the secular world, this deep yearning for a time before corruption, a space beyond social norms. The child represents a mode of experience that is protected, controlled—it performs the part of tabula rasa, and as such it offers proof that as humans we can be anything, that we are not condemned by our sinful past. Of course, childhood was not always considered the epitome of innocence; this is a modern invention, dating to the 18th century (Ariès 1962). Following theories of original sin, which held that all humans carry the guilt of Adam’s disobedience, children were understood as inherently sinful; they were small, faulty adults in need of discipline, correction, or worse, since they had no idea how to control their various impulses (Bernstein 2011).

Notions of childhood as soiled by original sin shifted to the now more well-known ideas of romantic childhood, thanks in part to John Locke (1975), who situated the child as simply a subject without experience and memory. For Locke, the child was an instance of natural humanity, revealing humanity’s *capacity* for knowledge and reason, without being tainted by the prejudices of actual knowledge in society. The child was pure and uncorrupt potential. Images of romantic childhood stress this idea of the child as barely part of the physical world, as belonging to a time out of history. This is achieved by making their bodies seem unreal or as distinct as possible from adults: dimpled and round, with unblemished skin (Higonnet 1998). In this sense, Locke and other Enlightenment thinkers used the child to imagine a secular humanity; as its exemplar, the figure of the child enabled humanity to reimagine itself as also essentially innocent, that is, as having the potential to act and shape its own future (Faulkner 2011). On the one hand, Enlightenment thinkers turned Judeo-Christian notions of innocence on their heads, not simply placing innocence in the past but identifying it as the key to the future; on the other hand, despite its shifting temporal location, innocence remains central to how we imagine nature and the limits of humanity.

Innocence demarcates human kinds according to their relationship to knowledge and action. For instance, locating innocence in the figure of the child leaves little space for actual childhood experiences. What happens when these experiences do not fit the parameters of innocence? Innocence carves out a conceptual space and time of unsullied hope, one that is linked to a freedom from knowledge. Yet the borders of this space are profoundly contested; rather than a given, this space is a political battleground. Understanding the work of innocence requires tracing which types of knowledge are named or counted as pure (which

experiences slip into a space of epistemic purity, unnoticed) and, by contrast, which ones somehow tip the balance and result in an expulsion from innocence.

Child soldiers, for instance, trouble the image of the child as innocent. And as Liisa Malkki (2010) has argued, child soldiers are seen as an abomination, a category mistake that leads to their being labeled “youth” or “teens” as opposed to “children” whenever possible, to set aside and protect a time of innocence, when they are still unworldly and untainted. Similarly, the undocumented minors crossing into the United States from Central America in great numbers in the summer of 2014 were not categorized or treated as children; they were called “minors,” no matter their age, and imprisoned in detention centers. While child soldiers are sullied by their involvement in war, the undocumented children were tainted by their association with gangs, drugs, and violence; they were rendered complicit in these crimes by virtue of coming from the same place—racially, geographically, and socioeconomically.

As these examples demonstrate, the concept of innocence does not describe a clear-cut state of epistemic or other purity. Rather, it helps distinguish morally acceptable forms of knowledge, action, and experience, and these are inevitably tied to one's being in the world. That is, innocence is defined not simply by a period of life called “childhood” or by outside standards such as age but by, as we just saw, class, gender, and racial background, among other positionalities, histories, and experiences. Certain conditions enable the space for an unsullied childhood; clearly class formation is important here, in configuring a space and time understood as pure, as empty or free of knowledge. But so is race: as feminist theorist bell hooks has noted, black children in the United States, particularly black boys, are never allowed to be children.³ This is also true for black girls, who, starting as early as five years old, are treated as more adult than their white counterparts, with presumed knowledge of topics like sex (Meyerson 2017). Racial regimes mean that they are never allowed this period of untroubled and ignorant life; they are immediately interpellated into the structures and hierarchies of society, which render their knowledge suspect. Historian Robin Bernstein (2011, 30–35) argues, in fact, that childhood innocence was from the very beginning racialized as *white* in the United States; it came into being in the second half of the 19th century in relation to its Other, the black child, who was constructed as a “pickaninny”—a nonfeeling, noninnocent, juvenile *worker*. In this sense, childhood was forged in the context of capitalism and slave labor—and innocence worked to mark the boundary of allowable, exploitative, racialized labor. Innocence thus produces and regulates ontologies of human kinds. When one is a noninnocent child, one is no longer a child—one is simply expelled from the category.

Even as it produces human kinds, innocence marks humanity's limits. Perhaps unsurprisingly, those associated

with innocence tend to be at humanity's edges; they mark its border, in the sense that they are not corrupt (as is a normative humanity), yet nor are they fully human in the Enlightenment sense of having reason, will, or autonomy. Women have been figured as innocent, for instance, particularly in the form of mother and child. This may be because white children's innocence was often transferable to surrounding people and things (Bernstein 2011). Yet for women by themselves, chastity or sexual integrity has been the most important thing about them, and in this sense, innocence is still inextricably tied to sexual innocence (Miller 2004; Rubin 1993). As we know, sex is a particularly dense site of struggle between knowledge and ignorance; the term *carnal knowledge* illustrates the battle over how to categorize different forms of action and experience.⁴ Kincaid describes innocence as simply “virginity coupled with ignorance” (1998, 55). For women, then, sex is considered the primary corrupting form of knowledge. To be innocent is to be chaste. Purity here—to be a “good woman”—is to actively embody performances of passionlessness (Bernstein 2011, 41). This is echoed over and over again in the history of rape cases—women who have been victims of sexual violence are figured immediately as guilty; the burden of proof is reversed, requiring that they prove *their innocence* rather than the guilt of their attackers. Indeed, in this way, innocence has helped produce new gendered and sexual ontologies: the requirement of passionlessness to claim innocence has carried over to homosexuality. In the struggle against HIV/AIDS, access to life-saving treatment required that queer bodies be rendered innocent, which entailed taking homosexuality out of the realm of choice and desire, placing it in the sphere of genetically determined nature or essence.

Humanitarian innocence, political consequences

Innocence does important work to produce human kinds by regulating distinctions between purity and impurity. Yet how has innocence come to occupy such an important place in the Euro-American political landscape? The following provides an example of how it has become central to contemporary politics, insofar as it creates a space for seemingly apolitical (or morally pure) action.

Let's turn to France in 1968 and the subsequent formation of Médecins sans frontières (MSF; Doctors without Borders), since it was here that a shift in a form of political engagement rendered innocence central to politics. This was not the only moment or place that the shift occurred, but it was certainly a critical one, particularly in the European and, later, global context. This is also the beginning of what Didier Fassin calls “humanitarian government” (2011, 1), or how moral sentiments have become an essential force in contemporary politics, directed from the more powerful to the weaker. The year 1968 marked the largest strike in the history of the French workers' movement, and the largest

mass movement in French history (Ross 2002, 3–4). The key players in the formation of MSF were all *soixante-huitards* ('68ers): at the time they were doctors or medical students, and Maoists or members of the Communist Party. These revolutionary doctors, who came together with a group of equally radical journalists, founded MSF in 1971.

While initially guided by the belief in a universal humanity grounded in equality and solidarity, MSF and the “new humanitarianism” soon blossomed into and helped to shape an era of moralist antipolitics. After the failure of '68 to transform the social and political order and after the disappointment of anticolonial revolutionary Marxist movements, Bernard Kouchner, one of MSF's founders, and many of his comrades from '68 radically changed their views. They turned away from engagement with what they thought of as politics—engaging with power relations in the struggle for a collective future—and instead embraced the belief that one can ultimately address only individual suffering; in this sense, they attended to what they conceived of as a universal humanity composed of suffering victims (Redfield 2013; Ross 2002; Vallaeys 2004). As former executive director of MSF-USA Nicolas de Torrenté wrote, “Humanitarian action's single-minded purpose [is] alleviating suffering, unconditionally and without any ulterior motive” (2004, 5). That is, politics in terms of the anticapitalist, anti-imperialist revolution dreamed of by the *soixante-huitards* was replaced by a defense of the principles of human rights, and by a view that separated victims from perpetrators, heroes from villains, in order to side with and defend the powerless (Ross 2002). Kouchner and MSF brought a form of action that appealed in its purported ability to *avoid* Machiavellian politics (Caldwell 2009). It was an ideology grounded in individualism, one that no longer allowed for the possibility of larger political change.⁵

Innocence was central both to the politics of this “antipolitics” and, ultimately, to defining morally legitimate suffering. This “new humanitarianism” was shaped by a frustration with and refusal of politics; consequently, it was driven by the search for an uncorrupted space of action. Innocence offers such a space of imagination, even as it calls forth and protects different versions of epistemic and moral purity. In this sense, the suffering victim driving humanitarian action quickly inhabited the conceptual space opened by the notion of innocence, even if it was not always identical to it—of course, humanitarianism is not *simply* a politics of innocence, and innocence clearly travels beyond its humanitarian deployments. While MSF maintains impartiality as a key principle, meaning that it offers assistance to people irrespective of their race, gender, religion, or political affiliation, in many humanitarian contexts—on the ground—innocence becomes the necessary accompaniment to suffering, required to designate the sufferer as worthy. That is, the suffering victim is best and most easily recognized by humanitarians when considered innocent—pure,

outside politics, outside history, indeed, outside time and place altogether (Ticktin 2011a). This figure is distinctly counterposed to the previous political protagonists of the 1960s and 1970s, such as the worker and the colonial militant, in that these are both highly situated, geographically, historically, racially, and of course politically.

On a practical level, humanitarians are guided by the principle of impartiality, but in practice, finite resources limit their action.⁶ While the goal is to treat everyone equally, whether they are perpetrators or victims, they themselves admit that they must triage, prioritizing those considered in the most serious and immediate danger. The concept of innocence helps in this process, as a way to grasp and measure vulnerability. Indeed, former MSF president Rony Brauman has criticized how moralist positions have marked humanitarianism, noting that the symbolic status of victim can in effect “only be granted in cases of unjustified or innocent suffering. . . . The point is that he [*sic*] must be 100% victim, a non-participant” (Brauman 1993, 154).

This process of triage is evident in the case of sexual violence. Before the early 2000s, survivors of sexual violence were not included in standard models of humanitarian aid delivery. In the collection of essays by MSF about humanitarian practices in the Congo Republic in the late 1990s, *Civilians under Fire* (Le Pape and Salignon 2003), former MSF-USA executive director Nicolas de Torrenté and former MSF president Jean-Hervé Bradol admit that this is because relief organizations search for the “ideal victims.” On the one hand, they acknowledge that this is strategic, insofar as it is a way to get donors interested; de Torrenté writes, “Deeply rooted images put a premium on the innocence of victims, making children, who are by definition blameless, the ideal recipients of care” (2003, x). On the other hand, they suggest that this focus, instrumental or not, pushes other categories of victims into the background. Survivors of sexual violence were not seen as innocent—as Bradol writes, “The raped woman rarely represents the ideal victim” (Bradol 2003, 11). This is because such survivors raised a number of unsettling issues for practitioners around violence and gender roles, which they felt were too political to engage. As a result, de Torrenté states that MSF reproduced forms of prejudice against women in general and survivors of sexual violence in particular. These discussions are haunted by the histories and treatment of women victims of rape, who were (and still are) seen as responsible for and consenting to their own rapes because of how they dressed or behaved, or where they had chosen to be. They are seen as too knowing and too agentic to be innocent.

In many ways, MSF's collection of essays marks the shift, since the early 2000s, in the humanitarian mandate; sexual violence now merits an immediate response from aid workers. This was not because humanitarianism stopped looking for innocent subjects; rather, there was a shift to seeing these women as innocent enough to be

compelling humanitarian subjects. This happened, in large part, through the medicalization of gender-based violence, which is a longer story related to its changing treatment by regimes of human rights and global health (Ticktin 2011b). Attention was transferred to health consequences such as infection with HIV, physical injury and trauma, unwanted pregnancies, reproductive health, and STDs. This medicalization of rape and sexual violence ended up shifting the blame and rendering the victims innocent of the harm they endured. More specifically, a focus on the vulnerable body in biomedical terms brackets off social and political identities and realities. The medicalization was helpful insofar as it allowed women to be abstracted from their political contexts, rendered blameless, and treated; it has been less helpful, however, insofar as it has worked to depoliticize the larger gendered inequalities that lead to such harm.

The conceptual space of innocence has been shaped and disseminated through the process of medicalization at the heart of medical humanitarianism; biomedicine, in its focus on the physical body, also generally disregards the role of intentionality, desire, or will. While MSF has primarily attended to health care in times of crisis, engaging innocence both honestly and strategically, humanitarianism as a field brings medicine into intersection with the law, and here once again, innocence has played an important role.

In my earlier research in France on the role of humanitarian exceptions in the politics of immigration (Ticktin 2011a), I found that those who were understood to be the most passive or guileless were the most likely to gain access to legal documents through humanitarian exceptions to the law. For instance, undocumented immigrants could be legalized (temporarily) in exceptional circumstances, such as severe illness, or as a result of gender-based or sexual violence, drawing on the process of medicalization to enhance their palatability as blameless. Again, the more “innocent” one appeared, the more likely it was that one would be issued documents. For example, the successful cases I observed included a child with cancer; a Malian woman infected with HIV by her husband, who brought home the infection after sleeping with other women; and an Algerian woman who had been raped and disfigured by her uncle. These are people who did nothing to cause their situation. As Fassin notes, humanitarian government tends to work by setting up a “scale of innocence and vulnerability” that works to privilege some, like HIV-positive children who are the ultimate innocents, but in the process, it also works to penalize others, like their mothers (2011, 167).

The humanitarian exceptions I tracked also increasingly included victims of human trafficking. Of course, the movement against trafficking has its other histories and precursors, such as the movement against white slavery, which, interestingly, also focused on purity. While current antitrafficking laws are concerned with trafficking for forced labor as well as for forced sex, trafficking for the purposes

of sex still receives the most publicity and emphasis transnationally, and one reason for this is the focus on and appeal of innocence. As anthropologist Carole Vance (2012) has long argued, the central characters in stories of sex trafficking are teenage girls and young women, putatively devoid of sexuality or knowledge, and sold into brothels.

In fact, human-trafficking cases—a subset of which are called “modern slavery”—perhaps best illustrate the need to appeal to innocence in the humanitarian logic. And they in turn reveal the contours of innocence as a political concept. Here, victims lack not only (sexual) knowledge but also intention, which enhances their identities as innocent. In my research, nearly all the “modern slaves” who were recognized and granted documents through humanitarian exceptions were young girls who had supposedly come to France naively, sexually innocent, and often without a choice. There was no room for their complicity in wanting a better life or to provide for their kin, or in taking opportunities to leave their homes, often with the help of their families; no room for sexual knowledge or experience. The girls were described as vulnerable, defenseless, lost, and excluded. They were portrayed as unable to comprehend their situations. In the process, sex work as work was either rendered invisible or criminalized.

As we can see from these examples, certain subjects are better positioned to fit into the conceptual framework of innocence. Gender configurations suggest that women are more easily understood as victims and as apolitical, and hence more easily interpellated into the role of moral purity. But the “Third World Woman”—as transnational feminist theorist Chandra Mohanty (1988, 333) has called the stereotypical suffering victim of oppressive patriarchal cultures—is perhaps *best* qualified to pass the test of innocence, insofar as women from the third world or Global South are often equated with passivity and apolitical corporeal existence. They are seen as without agency, docile, and in need of rescue (Abu-Lughod 2002; Mohanty 1988). Indeed, Ratna Kapur has called this “the victim subject” (2002). The point is that such gendered, racial hierarchies actually serve to qualify these women as innocent. Similarly, men can rarely qualify as such. In this sense, we see that innocence is part of a conceptual apparatus that demarcates human kinds, purporting to value the most naive, the most inactive, the most childlike, while simultaneously setting up another class of people on whom these innocents must depend. While innocence is valued, it shares its conceptual space with pitifulness. And a politics of pity, as Luc Boltanski (1999) suggests, is not about equality or justice; while justice is concerned with fairness and requires recourse to standards or conventions of equivalence, pity sets up two classes of people, the fortunate and the unfortunate, where the unfortunate are often regarded as victims.

Differently stated, even as innocence creates a pure space for humanity, it creates what Fassin has described,

referring to humanitarianism, as “hierarchies of humanity” (2010, 239). While the concept of innocence shifts according to the constellation of experiences and histories in which it is located, it nevertheless always carries with it the desire to protect and the impetus to take responsibility for those whom—in their want of knowledge—cannot take care of themselves. Guilelessness evokes the need for care; innocents cannot take responsibility for themselves. But this means that it props up a feeling of control in those who care for the innocent; it assures them not only of their power but also of their knowledge, insofar as the innocent person is oblivious. *It creates a class of saviors.* Gayatri Spivak (1988) called out one instance of this type of action, provoked by the idea of innocence and fed by the comfort of superiority in knowledge and power: she called it “white men saving brown women from brown men.” This is a script that continues to have enormous appeal, as we saw in US interventions in Iraq and Afghanistan in the name of saving their women and in the huge political following and money garnered by Somaly Mam and her foundation, which works to rescue girls from sex trafficking in places like Cambodia—until her own story of sexual slavery, recounted in her autobiography, *The Road of Lost Innocence*, was shown to be a lie (Marks 2014). As a space of purity, innocence itself appears outside history, and as such, it allows those who work as saviors to ignore the political and historical circumstances that created these victims. “White men who save brown women from brown men” are allowed to ignore their complicity in creating a category of people who need saving, and they need never ask whether these brown women actually want saving, since as innocents they are understood to lack desire or agency.⁷

This not only allows saviors to feel powerful or knowledgeable but also enables them to simultaneously capture innocence—to purify or absolve themselves. In other words, innocence also creates a savior class or subject, and they too make claims to innocence. If the people one is saving are understood as innocent, outside time and place, and one is intervening only to stop the suffering, how can this not be considered innocent too? This refers back to the meaning of explicit not-knowing in the concept of innocence: *in-noscere*, “not to know.” In the context of US history, James Baldwin (1998) understood such interventions to be a form of racial innocence, meaning that they were based on ignorance; he described this impermissible innocence as Americans’ refusal to deal with deeply entrenched forms of racial injustice, by holding on to ideologies of equality that undergird the American dream rather than facing the actual historical evidence (see also Balfour 1999). Baldwin was describing the way Americans prefer clinging to fantasies that suggest they can move into a race-blind future. Their ignorance allows the posture of innocence. Indeed, racial innocence is a form of deflection (Pierce 2012)—a not-knowing or obliviousness

that can be politically useful for those in power and that can prompt and justify further such pursuits of innocence.

In a similar vein, those inspired by humanitarian sentiments may try to bypass politics, claiming to act only as witnesses to injustice or in response to the immediacy of suffering, but the political innocence they proclaim ignores the privilege that allows them to act—it is a refusal to acknowledge the structural inequalities that allow them to *be* humanitarians, witnesses, or saviors. It also ignores the desire to feel morally upstanding and to absolve oneself of the guilt that accompanies such interventions; moreover, such moral claims can be pleasurable. As Sherene Razack (2007) writes in relation to the witnessing of pain, particularly in relation to racialized others, identifying with the suffering of the Other can too quickly slip into feeling that one has *become* that sufferer, both erasing the actual suffering subject and displacing any sense of responsibility toward them. Transnational feminist scholars such as Lila Abu-Lughod (2013) and Leti Volpp (2015) have critiqued the yearning for innocence among certain feminists whose politics are grounded in their desire to save others—such as Muslim women—and *to not know* about their own complicities in the disenfranchisement of those they are saving.

Expansions of innocence, the innocence of expansion

As a space of epistemic, experiential, or moral purity, innocence is always a work in progress. Insofar as there is no pure state of innocence—the concept derives from an imaginary or mythical past, and it enables us to imagine that we can be the authors of our future—a politics based on innocence requires not only the search for but also the production of innocent victims, since the “pure” victim is a placeholder, always just out of reach. For example, the recent focus on victims of human trafficking imagines young girls or women who have been kidnapped from their homes and locked away in brothels; yet this picture of innocence is complicated when we realize that many girls or women who engage in sex work actually chose to leave home, often encouraged by relatives, and generally knew what they would be doing, even if they did not know the exact conditions of their employment. Here, the victim is implicated in her own situation of exploitation, and her status quickly shifts from endangered to dangerous, innocent to delinquent. We lose her as an exemplar of innocence and must look for someone new.

Forms of politics based on innocence are increasingly prevalent globally—not only through humanitarianism or discourses and practices of human rights. Jackie Wang argues that the politics of innocence has infiltrated contemporary antiracist politics in the United States, now grounded on an empathetic structure of feeling that centers appeals to innocence. Thus it is OK to rally around

17-year-old African American Trayvon Martin, murdered in his own neighborhood in 2012 by the volunteer neighborhood watchman George Zimmerman, since he was innocent, but this is based on a whole class of people who, by this move, are categorized as guilty—a black man carrying a gun in his situation becomes killable. In other words, he is differentiated from other black men—the “bad” ones, the threatening ones (Wang 2012). The point here is not that people should be allowed to carry guns but that because innocence insists on purity and is coupled with guilt, and because our world is structured by these moral grammars, those who are not innocent are immediately deemed guilty: there is no space in between.

We can think of migrants in Europe similarly; for instance, since April 2015, innocence has been used to create a distinction in European public discourse between “refugees” and “illegal economic migrants” (Hage 2016; Holmes and Castañeda 2016; Kallius, Monterescu, and Rajaram 2016). Here asylum is primarily a moral, not a legal, distinction that purports to separate the deserving from the undeserving. “Real” refugees are seen as innocent—fleeing *real*, well-founded fears of persecution. They are understood as passive, vulnerable, and in need of saving. Economic migrants, in contrast, are portrayed as wily, trying to lie their way into enjoying the welfare and other benefits of Europe, and undermining not only European security but also European values. They are criminalized, and in the process, global inequality is shut out of the frame. Not only does this enable a form of politics that erases larger structural inequalities, but it also creates a greater need for prisons and detention centers for those designated guilty, literally feeding the prison industry.

Insofar as this type of (moralistic) politics depends on the figure of the innocent victim as the highest moral good—in an attempt to steer clear of explicit political solutions or goals—the politics of innocence works through a logic of *expansion*, in which new territories of innocence must be constantly discovered and incorporated. The innocent sufferer can never be isolated for long enough to keep it uncorrupted by history or context. In this sense, we are constantly *displacing politics to the limit of innocence*, a border that must be drawn and redrawn.

An example will help illustrate this idea of expansion. Days after the earthquake in Haiti in 2010, humanitarian aid flooded in. But it was not just for people; a number of NGOs came together to form the Animal Relief Coalition for Haiti (ARCH) to provide medical assistance to animal survivors. Since its inception, ARCH has claimed that its mobile veterinary clinic treated nearly 68,000 animals, including dogs, cats, horses, cattle, pigs, goats, and sheep.⁸ Similarly, in Japan in 2011, the American Humane Association conducted a large-scale animal rescue operation with its Japanese counterparts in response to the tsunami and earthquake. This was part of the American Humane

Association’s special animal emergency services program, called Red Star Rescue, which goes to disaster scenes with experts, volunteers, and mobile resources, such as an 82-foot mobile truck and veterinary clinic, carrying rescue boats, emergency equipment, generators, food, and medicine. Interestingly, the American Humane Association’s mission is to protect both animals and children; its mission is driven by the figures of innocence and vulnerability, whether human or not.

These acts of humanitarian rescue reflect larger cultural narratives: for instance, in a 2013 “global giving” contest, the top four positions went to animal causes, which were represented by photos of innocent, suffering animals; these included giving money to build a roof for 150 animals in Cartagena, Colombia, and rescuing abandoned companion birds. The next few slots went to causes for women and children.⁹ There are many such examples, including practices like “Chihuahua airlifts,” to rescue “homeless” Chihuahuas and bring them to new homes for adoption (Bustamente 2011).

The story line is familiar. The victims being rescued here recall poor women, innocent children. And like them, these animals are liminal figures, at the border of humanity. While animals are selectively incorporated into this politics of humanity in new ways, they do not represent a novel terrain of innocence; they have been variously included in and excluded from this category of universal solidarity over time. Historian Joanna Bourke (2011) writes about a woman known as the Earnest Englishwoman, who in 1872 asked to let women “become animal” in order to reap the benefits they were denied because they were not part of “mankind.” Animal cruelty organizations have a long history, having aided in the project of creating a compassionate sensibility in humans, and as such, in producing the very category of humanity (Esmeir 2012). Some felt that being kind to animals would help protect humans, with the idea that reform for animals would help humans who were in an “animal-like” condition, including immigrants and racial Others. Others argued against cruelty to animals as a moral wrong in and of itself. Arguments to this end were made as early as 1776. The first movements against animal cruelty in the United States and Europe were founded in the 19th century. To be sure, this was very much a middle-class movement, used to civilize the lower orders (Sznajder 2001). The American Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals, for instance, was founded in 1864 in New York. But animals have not always been considered innocent; in medieval Europe and colonial America, animals were invested with legal personalities and tried in court; they testified and were executed for legal transgressions. This shift to seeing animals as innocent was part of the growth of secular liberalism and the move away from religious understandings of original sin, which held both animals and children responsible for their conditions.

Similarly, environmentalism has its own history of engaging with innocence by way of nonhumans, though it is by no means identical to the movements against animal cruelty and is often even in tension with them. Environmentalists generally focus on the “nature” side of the modernist divide between humans and nature, and they are more attentive to populations than individuals. In recent years, however, environmental and conservation movements have used many similar strategies to draw attention to the plight of endangered species and, now, to climate change. In particular, the attention to “flagship species” overlaps with humanitarian sentiments for nonhumans: this is the focus on popular, charismatic species likely to trigger sympathy, raise awareness, and gain resources. Most famously, perhaps, is the giant panda, whose image has been adopted as the logo of the World Wide Fund for Nature (Lorimer 2007). In fact, some of these same affective strategies are engaged by the recent move to depict mother earth as a legal person at risk from climate change.

Despite the historical continuities with humanitarian and environmentalist logics, there are new economies, technologies, and infrastructures that build on these logics, instituting a particular incarnation of innocence and giving it a new shape and valence. Animals are seen as innocent subjects that need protection in many new ways: not only through humanitarian rescue but also the protection of their right to mobility. The Israeli West Bank Separation Barrier—or Wall—offers an example. Initiated in 2002 by Israel at the height of the second intifada, the barrier comprises electric fencing, iron, barbed wire, and a lot of concrete snaking in multiple directions; it is imposing and mostly impassable. And yet the barrier includes small holes for animals such as hedgehogs, ibex, and gazelles, thanks to the efforts of Israeli ecologists, who insisted that animal families—in contrast to human families—should not be separated. I saw the same at the US-Mexico border wall. They too have created small holes for animals such as the ocelot (a type of wild cat) in the border fence (see Figure 1). Debates about who or what can pass through the wall have landed in both Israeli and US courts, which have adjudicated how border enforcement affects the mobility of wildlife, revealing not only how much the lives of animals are seen to matter but also how they are framed as innocent bystanders to immigration and security wars. Indeed, I have been finding that across the Global North there is increasing concern for innocent animals hurt by the proliferation of border walls. For instance, newspapers report protests at the new border wall between Croatia and Slovenia—Croatians are upset that animals are getting caught in the barbed wire. In one newspaper, graphic images of maimed owls and deer caught in the fence were accompanied by text stating, “These are the horrific images of suffering animals” (Rosc 2015) (see Figure 2).

Not only does the larger politics of border walls and global migration fall out of the frame here, but so too does the larger context of institutions and practices, like factory farming and animal experimentation, which affect billions of animals, leaving just a tiny few to be saved. The larger circulation of capital and labor is rendered invisible, whether it has to do with humans or nonhumans, including any way to address its workings or effects. The concept of innocence works by making people feel as if they are already doing good in the world, that they are already fighting the good fight, in ways that make them feel not only virtuous but also pure.

While there are surely several overlapping reasons for incorporating animals into these industries—including changing perceptions of animals as part of larger kinship structures and as rights-bearing subjects—there is nevertheless something particular about this set of developments.¹⁰ This set of industries does not include all animals, so we cannot say it is simply the result of rethinking either the moral or the ontological categories of human, animal, and nature; instead, it focuses on animals that can fit into the conceptual framework of innocence, from companion animals to animals like chimps, dolphins, and pandas. This includes docility, often meekness, and an ability to obey. As one example of this, biologists working with the US Fish and Wildlife Service at the US-Mexico border explain that images of ocelots are critical in protecting the area’s wildlife. That is, as part of a larger conservationist agenda, they have a mandate to protect the innocent, endangered ocelots, but they also use this knowing that ocelots are the gateway to possibilities for protection for other, less innocent-looking creatures.

What makes these seem innocent? Part of it involves not just the conceptual space of innocence but its aesthetics. This includes what Jamie Lorimer (2007) has called “non-human charisma” and aesthetics like cuddliness and cuteness, which trigger strong emotional responses. Sianne Ngai (2005) describes the aesthetics of cuteness, and suggests it accentuates helplessness and vulnerability. Innocence shares many of its formal properties with cuteness, organized around small, helpless, abject, or deformed objects: for instance, large eyes that evoke distress. These induce both the desire for mastery as well as the desire to help and to cuddle. As ethnologists have long noted, cuteness is associated with juvenile features in humans as well as animals, and it is accompanied by a desire to protect (Konrad 1971). Innocence, like cuteness, is a minor aesthetic concept (unlike the more prestigious ones like the beautiful, sublime, and ugly), and its very diminutiveness is critical to its appeal. Indeed, innocence, like cuteness, seems to name an aesthetic encounter based on an exaggerated difference in power; it works in relation to a socially disempowered Other—the lack of animal “speech” only adds to this effect.

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Figure 1. The US-Mexico border wall, Brownsville, Texas, February 15, 2015. At bottom, there is an 8" x 11" opening for animals to pass through. (Miriam Ticktin) [This figure appears in color in the online issue]



Figure 2. A great horned owl caught in a fence. This image appeared on the Slovenian online news site *Svet* in an article about the new border wall with Croatia. The article condemned the suffering of animals caused by fences. (Courtesy of Blanford Nature Center) [This figure appears in color in the online issue]

It is in this sense that innocence, as a political concept that has become central to a politics of help, pity, and rescue, actually encourages a form of expansion, colonizing new landscapes to produce innocent victims, reproducing a certain sentimental political project of “protection” in the process—one might call it a predatory compassion.

The ends of innocence

Many concepts are used to name and manage the border of politics and of humanity. For instance, Giorgio Agamben's (1998) *Homo Sacer* describes a space at the heart of politics that is included by its very exclusion, a

conceptual space that stands at once inside and outside politics. Innocence is part of tangled convergences with such concepts that seek to manage and regulate distributions of knowledge and power, deservingness and blame, life and qualified life, potentiality and hopelessness. It is also part of a cluster of moral concepts, along with suffering, victimhood, and vulnerability. I conclude by briefly parsing the differences in this cluster, to think through the overall structure of the political argument that innocence participates in and, ultimately, to pry open a space to imagine a world without innocence.

Suffering, for instance, is not limited to those who are innocent. Rather, today, it is associated with the concept of a universal humanity. This notion of common suffering as the basis of humanity developed in the 18th century, with Enlightenment thinkers like Rousseau (Sznajder 2001); one might say it accompanied the democratic project and the shift away from a religious belief in the blessedness of suffering. “Humanity” began to refer to a shared sentiment of sympathy or benevolence—not shared species or biological fact. In this sense, the construction of a humane, secular society required the elimination of suffering; meaningless pain and suffering were eschewed. Humanitarianism in its current form developed to respond to a global humanity, understood as the capacity to suffer. Yet, while the concept of suffering pretends to universality, and while the humanitarian argument is that all suffering should be alleviated, there is a tension at suffering’s conceptual core: in the liberal secular project, some kinds of suffering have been seen as gratuitous—as more inhuman—than others. As both Talal Asad (2003) and Samira Esmeir (2012) note, suffering and pain have been used as both tools for and measures of the progress toward a modern, liberal, “civilized” humanity. Asad suggests that some kinds of suffering are justified as helping one to become human—those that are seen to be carefully calibrated and used to rational ends, such as modern warfare or prisons; meanwhile, others are considered barbaric, such as torture, which people see as excessive, irrational. Innocence plays on this tension, qualifying expressions of suffering, rendering some more warranted than others; it creates a moral distinction between unnecessary (innocent) and unavoidable (necessary) suffering. At stake here is what counts as suffering and how we can recognize it. Innocence parses different kinds of suffering, qualifying them; it provides a moral and cultural frame by which to judge them. Differently stated, innocence inserts hierarchy into the concept of suffering. Suffering could be understood in other ways—perhaps as more wide ranging—without innocence.

Victimhood is also part of a moral constellation with the concept of innocence; the phrase *innocent victim* occurs so often that it can be difficult to think of *innocent* and *victim* apart. Victims of natural disasters such as earthquakes or tsunamis are the incarnation of this. But this

understanding was made possible in part by the victims’ rights movements of the 1980s in the United States and France, which gave victimhood a new public and social presence, associated with trauma, which in turn eliminated the suspicion of victims—they were henceforth considered innocent in their claims and deserving of either compensation or treatment (Fassin and Rechtman 2009; Herman 1992). Innocents need not be victims—children are one such example. And victims need not be innocent. One can be a victim of a crime without being innocent, as we know in the cases of women who kill their abusers. Another example from the 1970s shows some of the complexity within the concept of victimhood: I refer here to debates in the United Nations about whether everyday people (i.e., civilians) who were part of occupying or colonial regimes, and who were killed as part of liberation struggles, should be considered “innocent victims” under the laws of war. This debate took place in the context of struggles for decolonization all over Africa, especially in South Africa under apartheid, and was part of negotiations at the United Nations over the definition of terrorism (Blumenau 2014). Could (violent) acts of liberation be labeled terrorist, and if so, should the victims be considered innocent? Ultimately, it was accepted that victims could be “guilty” but still victims—that is, they were guilty by virtue of being part of an occupying regime (i.e., South African apartheid) and therefore somehow complicit in its violence and oppression. When decoupled from innocence, victimhood becomes a more complicated subject position, which can be tied to an act of harm and not necessarily to a fixed identity as someone pure or undeserving of harm. In other words, victimhood need not be a moral identity; it can also be a medical condition or a legal category, which, as discussed, allows for more flexibility and contestation, and a whole new set of debates, for better or worse.¹¹

Finally, innocence is perhaps most often thought about together with vulnerability. Both vulnerable and innocent subjects are seen as needing protection; both cannot fully care for themselves. There is an element of frailty in each; a susceptibility to harm. And in both cases, the subjects verge on being pitiful, even undignified, insofar as a normative, liberal idea of humanity is grounded not simply on ideas of rationality, autonomy, and determination but on physical wholeness (Dean 2015). Feminist theorists like Judith Butler (2016) have attempted to shift understandings of vulnerability, understanding it not in opposition to political agency but precisely as inherent to political action: we mobilize vulnerability as a practice of political resistance to demand the material infrastructures and social conditions necessary for everyone to live. While I am not entirely convinced that vulnerability is a fundamental ontological condition, these theories nevertheless make clear that vulnerability allows for relationality; one is vulnerable in relation to something or someone. Innocence, however, is a

concept that stands on its own, even when contrasted with its binary others, such as guilt, knowledge, or sexuality; one is innocent or one is not. Because it is about purity, it does not allow for gradations—for being *partly* innocent. Innocence patrols the borders of power and powerlessness, rendering them incommensurable, while vulnerability leaves room for negotiation—it allows room for degrees of powerlessness while allowing some measure of action in the world.

In this sense, a world without innocence would not be a world without morality or care; it would not need to refuse the recognition of vulnerability, suffering, or victimhood. It would also not need to be a world of total guilt or unbridled, unchecked desire. To think beyond innocence is precisely to challenge the binaries that structure our moral vocabularies. It would, however, be a world without purity and without absolutism. Feminist scholars like Donna Haraway (1991) have long argued against this search for purity, suggesting that there is no innocent standpoint, no place of moral transcendence. The opposite of innocence in this sense is not guilt but *impurity*. A world without innocence, then, would embrace this contaminated reality and let it be the site of new political emergence.

As a general concept, innocence works particularly well to regulate the meanings of epistemic and moral purity, and as such to manage deservingness. As a *political* concept, however, innocence must be recognized as broad reaching, searching to include whatever it can in *an always incomplete capture of purity*. Innocence at once sets aside a space of life unsullied by knowledge or politics, yet it institutes a pathetic, docile figure at the heart of this space. If we did not fetishize purity and simplicity—if innocence did not constitute power and powerlessness as incommensurable—could we avoid a politics of rescue, one that cannot help but produce hierarchies of humanity? Without innocence, might we have a chance at an entirely different ethico-political life?

Notes

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1. *Oxford English Dictionary*, s.v. “innocence, n.,” accessed August 18, 2017, <http://www.oed.com/view/Entry/96292?redirectedFrom=Innocence>.

2. According to the *OED*, Thomas Hobbes invoked this meaning in *Leviathan* (1651) in speaking of a sovereign prince who put to death an innocent subject.

3. Public lecture at the New School for Social Research, New York, November 5, 2013.

4. For Joanna Faulkner (2011, 333), carnal knowledge assumes a kind of ignorance that in turn makes way for pleasure.

5. MSF, however, grew out of a revolutionary context in which populations in danger, not simply individuals, were also part of its mandate (Redfield 2013).

6. I am primarily speaking of the type of medical humanitarianism that was shaped by MSF and that includes, for example, Médecins du monde (Doctors of the World).

7. Leti Volpp (2006) gives an example of this with journalist Nicholas Kristof.

8. International Fund for Animal Welfare, “Animal Rescue Coalition Meets Objectives and Concludes Earthquake Relief in Haiti,” press release, May 3, 2011, accessed August 3, 2017, <http://www.ifaw.org/united-states/news/animal-rescue-coalition-meets-objectives-and-concludes-earthquake-relief-haiti>.

9. GlobalGiving, “GlobalGiving 2013 Photo Contest,” accessed August 22, 2013, <https://www.globalgiving.org/dy/v2/poll/photo-contest-2013/>.

10. Dolphins were accorded legal personhood in a vote by the American Association for the Advancement of Science, and great apes actually have *human* rights in Spain.

11. Playing with the idea of innocence and victimhood can have many consequences, as we have seen in Israeli-occupied Palestine, where a tactic of the Israeli army has been to fire warning shots onto the roofs of Palestinian civilians, in buildings suspected to contain weapons, supposedly to tell them to evacuate (“roof knocking”). If they do not leave within a few minutes, they are no longer considered innocent civilians but as complicit in Palestinian terrorism, and hence killable.

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Racial Innocence: Performing American Childhood from Slavery to Civil Rights | Bernstein

Week 5, Class 2 (Optional)

Chapter 1: Tender Angels, Insensate Pickaninnies — The Divergent Paths of Racial Innocence — pp. 30–68

Bernstein, Robin. 2011. "Tender Angels, Insensate Pickaninnies: The Divergent Paths of Racial Innocence." In *Racial Innocence: Performing American Childhood from Slavery to Civil Rights*. New York University Press. pp. 30–68.

1

Tender Angels, Insensate Pickaninnies

The Divergent Paths of Racial Innocence

In an advertising trade card from the 1890s, an African American girl smiles as she cuddles an armful of cotton (figure 1.1 and plate 1).¹ She advertises Cottolene, a lard substitute made out of cottonseed oil and animal fat.² The girl is well dressed and also well fed, as her chubby face and limbs attest. A yellow flower decorates her pigtail. The girl replicates the qualities of cuteness that coalesced at the turn of the twentieth century: her eyes are large in proportion to her head, her nose is small, her face is broad, her lips are plump but not to the point of caricature, and her expression is serene.³ Dimples lightly accentuate her round cheeks and elbows. The girl holds the cotton as if it were a baby; the cotton seems almost to snuggle against the girl, to return her embrace. Everything—the girl, the cotton, the countryside—is soft and clean. It is hard to imagine a more tender, appealing image of child labor.

A 1916 photograph of a white girl picking cotton (figure 1.2) pictures the pain and poverty that the Cottolene trade card screens out.⁴ The photograph is attributed to Lewis Hine, a documentary photographer in the tradition of Jacob Riis. Hine was a social reformer who used his camera to reveal the lives of laborers. Beginning in 1907, Hine worked for the National Child Labor Committee (NCLC), for which he is believed to have produced this photograph of Callie Campbell, age eleven. Callie Campbell is as thin as the Cottolene girl is plump, and the photograph's caption makes plain the white girl's feelings about her labor: "No, I don't like it very much." The Cottolene girl, in contrast, has no cause for discontent: in her fantasy milieu, cotton bolls puff out of the plants; they seem to give themselves up, almost to pick themselves. In contrast, the cotton plants that surround Callie Campbell are straggly and low to the



Figure 1.1. An African American girl cuddles a puff of cotton. Trade card for Cottolene, a lard substitute. N. K. Fairbank and Company, circa 1890s. Courtesy of the American Antiquarian Society.

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Figure 1.2. Photograph of child laborer, taken for the National Child Labor Committee, attributed to Lewis Hine, 1916. The photograph's original caption reads, "Callie Campbell, 11 years old, picks 75 to 125 pounds of cotton a day, and totes 50 pounds of it when sack gets full. 'No, I don't like it very much.'" Courtesy of the Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division, National Child Labor Committee Collection.

ground; she must stoop to pick them. The Cottolene girl stands front and center, meeting the viewer's gaze; like the cotton plants behind her, she withholds nothing from the consumer. Campbell, however, crosses one arm in front of her body and lowers her head, frowning suspiciously at the photographer. Hine carefully includes signs of Campbell's suffering within his frame: a bonnet inadequately defends against the sun; long sleeves fend off the plants' prickles; and Campbell drags a sack that is longer than she is tall.⁵ The caption specifies the bag's weight and juxtaposes the high poundage with the girl's young age: "Callie Campbell, 11 years old, picks 75 to 125 pounds of cotton a day, and totes 50 pounds of it when sack gets full." In contrast, the Cottolene girl's puffy cotton seems weightless, even cloud-like. The black girl's labor is unlabored; the white girl suffers under her burdens. Hine's image protests the use of an

innocent white child as labor; the Cottolene advertisement sells a black child's labor as innocent.

Together, these two images emblemize the flexibility of ideology at the conjunction of childhood and innocence. Childhood in combination with innocence was able to figure, by the turn of the century, in sharply differing political agendas (for and against child labor, in this example) because of the ways in which the concept of childhood innocence changed during the nineteenth century. This chapter charts those changes, arguing that in the second half of the nineteenth century, pain functioned as a wedge that split childhood innocence, as a cultural formation, into distinct black and white trajectories. White children became constructed as tender angels while black children were libeled as unfeeling, noninnocent nonchildren (and this dyadic divergence, a “melodrama in black and white” in Linda Williams's term, largely erased nonblack children of color from popular representation). Through this polarization, racial innocence—that is, the use of childhood to make political projects appear innocuous, natural, and therefore justified—emerged.

Neither black nor white childhood was monolithic in representation, and certainly not in lived experience, during this period. Representations of white children especially diversified during the second half of the nineteenth century—so much so that Catherine Reef characterized the period of 1860 to 1905 as an “age of contrasts” in the lives and depictions of (white) children.⁶ Books about angelic white children shared shelf space with books about bad boys and hoydens, and middle-class children became “priceless,” in Viviana Zelizer's term, while working-class and poor children sweated in factories and fields.⁷ Representations of African American children were less diverse, but variation existed here, too. Most depictions of African American children were denigrating, but some authors, white and black, produced fictional black child characters that were complex and mostly or fully realized; examples include Jacob Abbott's *Rainbow* and Harriet Wilson's *Frado*, to be discussed later in this chapter.⁸

Representations of white and of black children each varied, then, but not in equivalent ways. White child characters were depicted as innocent (even the “bad boy” that emerged in the final quarter of the nineteenth century in the work of Thomas Bailey Aldrich and Mark Twain was mischievous or wild, a “good-bad boy,” in Leslie Fiedler's term, rather than truly wicked).⁹ Only the rarest of white child characters was wholly lacking in innocence, and when such a character appeared, he or she usually met a terrible fate and thus invited the reader to identify against rather

than with the character.¹⁰ Representations of black children, in contrast, were increasingly and overwhelmingly evacuated of innocence. As Karen Sánchez-Eppler has argued, innocence defined nineteenth-century childhood, and not vice versa; therefore, as popular culture purged innocence from representations of African American children, the black child was redefined as a nonchild—a “pickaninny.”¹¹

The pickaninny was an imagined, subhuman black juvenile who was typically depicted outdoors, merrily accepting (or even inviting) violence.¹² The word (alternatively spelled “picaninny” or “piccaninny”) dates to the seventeenth century, at which time it described any child of African descent; in the nineteenth century, the word was used pejoratively and in reference mainly to black children in the United States and Britain, but also to aboriginal children of the Americas, Australia, and New Zealand (in this case, the black-white dyad erases the specificity of nonblack children of color by absorbing them into blackness).¹³ The word’s origins are disputed, but the term may derive from the Portuguese word “pequenino,” meaning a tiny child.¹⁴ Characteristics of the pickaninny include dark or sometimes jet-black skin, exaggerated eyes and mouth, the action of gorging (especially on watermelon), and the state of being threatened or attacked by animals (especially alligators, geese, dogs, pigs, or tigers). Pickaninnies often wear ragged clothes (which suggest parental neglect) and are sometimes partially or fully naked. Genitals or buttocks are often exposed, and not infrequently targeted for attack by animals. In some of the most degrading constructions, pickaninnies shit or piss in public. Of course, no individual pickaninny image includes all these characteristics; and some pickaninnies are constructed as clean, well-dressed, and engaged in domestic chores (this is especially true of pickaninny images emblazoned on kitchenwares such as dishtowels). Some pickaninny figures are nonindividuated and doltish as cows, but others are clever as monkeys. When threatened, pickaninny characters might ignore danger or quake in exaggerated fear; when attacked, they might laugh or yelp, but in either case, they never experience or express pain or sustain wounds in any remotely realistic way. For example, in E. W. Kemble’s 1898 alphabet book (see Chapter 2), two pickaninny characters play with a gun that accidentally fires.¹⁵ As the characters are flung violently through the air, they look angry but not frightened or pained, much less wounded or killed. It is this absence of pain that unifies the construction of the pickaninny across differences. The pickaninny may be animalistic or adorable, ragged or

neat, frightened or happy, American or British, but the figure is always juvenile, always of color, and always resistant if not immune to pain.

The pickaninny was a major figure in U.S. cultural history and as such must be taken seriously. Because pickaninnies were juvenile yet excluded from the exalted status of “child,” they seemed not to matter. If, as Kirk Savage has argued, a granite monument declares its own necessity and inevitability, then a trade card emblazoned with a pickaninny claimed to be ephemeral, transitory, consumable, and discardable.¹⁶ The pickaninny appeared to be, in all senses of the word, minor. That appearance of insignificance provided cover for a justification of violence against African American children. A focus on the pickaninny intervenes in the scholarly argument that U.S. popular culture has fetishized and commodified the pain of African Americans. Debra Walker King writes that “the pain-free, white American body exists easily in the cultural imagination,” whereas “the black body is always a memorial to African and African American historical pain.”¹⁷ Examination of adult-oriented culture amply supports this perspective, but the lens of childhood inverts it. The unfeeling, unchildlike pickaninny is the mirror image of both the always-already pained African American adult and the “childlike Negro.”

Today, the Cottolene girl might seem adorably childlike and not at all like the dehumanized pickaninnies in Kemble’s alphabet book. At the close of the nineteenth century, however, a different mode of vision dominated, and in this context, a representation of a black child could seem adorable but not innocent, childlike, or even human. The writer William Cowper Brann made exactly this point when he wrote shortly before his death in 1898, “There is probably nothing on earth ‘cuter’ than a nigger baby; but, like other varieties in the genus ‘coon,’ they are not considered very valuable additions to society.”¹⁸ For Brann, cuteness in no way contradicted or mitigated the categorization of a “nigger baby” as a variety of the animalistic “genus ‘coon,’” nor did the infant’s cuteness imbue it with value. This chapter restores cultural context to make sense of this apparent non-sense, revealing the stakes in representations of black children in the second half of the long nineteenth century. In the context of the history that this chapter maps, the Cottolene girl’s baby-shaped pile of white cotton emerges as arguably more childlike, more innocent, and more deserving of protection than its black, juvenile reaper.

Pain, and the ability to feel it, is what separated Callie Campbell from the Cottolene girl, and pain is what divided white childhood from black childhood in U.S. popular culture. The respective images suggested that

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Callie Campbell's labors pained her; she belonged not in the field but in school or at home. The Cottolene girl, in contrast, felt no pain; she belonged exactly where she was. Thus the two images made agricultural labor seem, respectively, unjust for white children because it caused them to suffer and natural for black pickaninnies, who did not suffer. These turn-of-the-century images could function in this way because over the previous half-century, pain became a wedge that split one idea—childhood innocence—into diverging paths that produced opposing meanings in black and white. Pain divided tender white children from insensate pickaninnies. At stake in this split was fitness for citizenship and inclusion in the category of the child and, ultimately, the human.

The Emergence of Childhood Innocence

Human societies have long acknowledged differences between juvenile and mature people (as in the biblical verse, “When I was a child, I spake as a child, I understood as a child, I thought as a child: but when I became a man, I put away childish things”¹⁹). However, the characterization of that difference as innocence versus experience—that is, children’s sinlessness, asexuality, and obliviousness to politics versus adults’ sexuality and worldliness—originated, as historian Philippe Ariès famously showed, with the European Enlightenment.²⁰ In North America, the belief that children are innocent did not become widespread until the late eighteenth century. Before that time, the Calvinist doctrine of infant depravity—the belief that people are born with original sin—dominated. According to this doctrine, children are inherently sinful and sexual and are therefore vulnerable to the worst fate imaginable: if they should die before they achieve Christian salvation, they are doomed to eternal hellfire.²¹ High child mortality rates motivated parents to limit children’s sinful behaviors by any means, and as early as possible, because a child’s soul literally depended on control of the body. As Karin Calvert has shown, colonial material culture, including swaddling and walking stools, compelled infant bodies into upright positions and thus, parents hoped, hurried children out of uncontrolled, vulnerable infancy and toward mature piety.²² Children were “better whipt, than damned,” as Cotton Mather wrote; and parents who believed similarly sought to extinguish sexual and other misbehaviors through swift corporal punishment.²³ Eighteenth-century minister John Wesley famously called upon parents to

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Break their [children's] wills. . . . [B]egin this work before they can run alone, before they can speak plain, perhaps before they can speak at all. Whatever pains it costs, break the will, if you would not damn the child. . . . If you spare the rod, you spoil the child; if you do not conquer, you ruin him. Break his will now, and his soul shall live, and he will probably bless you to all eternity.²⁴

Pain, then, was a crucial tool by which to save a child's soul. Salvation depended upon two co-factors: the parents' administration of pain and the child's reception of it. Despite these measures, however, infant depravity and damnation remained terrifyingly beyond parents' physical control: no matter how often or vigorously parents applied the rod, they could never be certain that their children were not damned.

In the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, however, Calvinism and the doctrine of original sin gradually declined, child-rearing practices changed dramatically, and the belief that children were inherently innocent proliferated.²⁵ The change registers in the contrast between Anne Bradstreet's and William Wordsworth's respective takes on birth. The verse "Childhood" from Bradstreet's 1650 poem, "The Four Ages of Man," described the infant as

. . . conceiv'd in sin, and born in sorrow,
A nothing, here to day, but gone to morrow.
Whose mean beginning blushing can't reveale,
But night and darknesse, must with shame conceal.²⁶

Bradstreet's seventeenth-century association of childhood with original sin, sex, birth-pains, and vulnerability to death contrasts with Wordsworth's 1807 "Ode: Intimation of Immortality." For Wordsworth, birth is neither a result of sin nor an exercise in sorrow; rather,

Our birth is but a sleep and a forgetting:
The Soul that rises with us, our life's Star,
Hath had elsewhere its setting,
And cometh from afar:
Not in entire forgetfulness,
And not in utter nakedness,
But trailing clouds of glory do we come

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From God, who is our home:
Heaven lies about us in our infancy!²⁷

In the century and a half that separated Bradstreet's and Wordsworth's poems, conception transformed from "sin" and a "mean beginning" of "shame" to a disembodied, heavenly launch of the soul. Birth was no longer a woman's "sorrow" but an infant's "sleep" and "forgetting" of its recent "home" in God's realm. And the infant itself, in the seventeenth century "a nothing" that may die "to morrow" became by the nineteenth century a sacred comet "trailing clouds of glory" and ushering heaven itself into the home to surround the baby. Wordsworth's poem reflected cultural changes already under way throughout the Western world and also extended those changes, especially in the United States. As Barbara Garlitz has documented, references to Wordsworth's ode surfaced widely in poems, sermons, and child-rearing manuals in both Great Britain and the United States throughout the nineteenth century.²⁸ With this proliferation, Americans quoted Wordsworth's ode to express their own thoughts, and burgeoning mass culture metabolized and circulated these quotations as part of the literary formation of the "romantic child."²⁹

The decline of the notion of original sin and the emergence of romantic childhood—the child as *tabula rasa*, or uncorrupted element of nature—gave rise to a new concept: childhood sexual purity. From the mid-nineteenth century until the early twentieth, when Sigmund Freud upset the applecart, Americans largely regarded children as innately devoid of sexual desire. This pre-Freudian belief, which has become profoundly unfamiliar, gains clarity through a brief consideration of nineteenth-century views regarding childhood masturbation and privacy. In the late nineteenth century, advice manuals frantically warned parents to prevent childhood masturbation and the degeneracy the practice supposedly caused. A crucial way to prevent masturbation, according to doctors, was to sequester each child in an individual bedroom. That privacy would prevent, rather than abet, masturbation seems counterintuitive today, but the advice makes sense within the context of a belief in fundamental childhood sexual purity. Essentially innocent children by definition lack any impulse that could cause them independently to discover or to invent masturbation. However, an innocent child, exposed to a corrupted child or a servant who masturbated, could imitate the practice. In this sense, masturbation was considered a sexually transmitted disease. The common practice of children sleeping together, or of children sleeping with

servants, was understood to spread the contagion of masturbation, and therefore doctors and reformers called ardently for individual sleeping arrangements.³⁰

As the example of beliefs about masturbation shows, the child was viewed as fundamentally innocent of sexual desire unless corrupted by an outside force. This child was not defined by absence (asexuality or pre-sexuality) but rather by sexual innocence: a fully present, embodied state of purity. This pure child was the sentimental angel-child, which became, by the mid-nineteenth century, a dominant formation within American childhood. In the words of Karin Calvert, (white) children of the second half of the nineteenth century were considered “virtually angels incarnate who, should they die in infancy, would transmute back into their angelic state.”³¹ The emblematic angel-child was, as many scholars have noted, Stowe’s Little Eva.

The sentimental child, as a sexually pure angel of the house, functioned as a crucial figure in what Barbara Welter has called the cult of true womanhood and Aileen Kraditor has called the cult of domesticity.³² The cult of true womanhood, as Welter famously argued, was built upon four pillars: piety, purity, submissiveness, and domesticity. Nancy Cott revised and deepened Welter’s notion of “purity” when she introduced the concept of “passionlessness”: for Cott, passionlessness, a “central tenet of Victorian sexual ideology,” was a “view that women lacked sexual aggressiveness, that their sexual appetites contributed a very minor part (if any part at all) to their motivations, that lustfulness was simply uncharacteristic.”³³ Cott and Welter agree that the cardinal virtues of womanhood presented an ideal that no historical women fulfilled perfectly. *Woman* may have been passionlessly pure, pious, submissive, and domestic, but historical *women* always experienced a gap between themselves and the ideal.

Some scholars have problematically read the sentimental child as an apparent bridge over this gulf—that is, as the ultimate fulfillment of the cult of true womanhood. In this view, children, especially girls, make better women than women do. Deborah Gorham argues this point most strongly: in her view, the “ideal of feminine purity is implicitly asexual,” and this pillar of the cult of true womanhood created a paradox for Victorian wives and mothers who were assumed to be fulfilling their duties as sexual partners to their husbands. A girl, however, was assumed not to be engaging in sex, and therefore “could be perceived as a wholly unambiguous model of . . . sexual purity.”³⁴ A girl “could represent the quintessential angel in the house”—above and beyond her mother.³⁵ The problem

with this argument is that the primary texts suggest far greater complexity. For example, when Grace Greenwood (Sara Jane Clarke) wrote in 1846 that “true feminine genius” is “perpetual childhood,”³⁶ she described adult femininity as a form of childhood, not vice versa.³⁷ In 1842, Elizabeth Oakes Smith described an adult character named Eva (who may have informed Stowe’s character of the same name) as a “true woman” because she combined a “woman’s love and gentleness” with “childlike simplicity.”³⁸ The suggestion that Victorian girls, or children more generally, fulfilled the virtues of true womanhood better than women did implies dynamics of competition and unidirectionality (children as women, not women as children) that the primary texts do not support.

I argue, in contrast, that the sentimental child presented an exceptionally credible vessel to contain the idea of passionlessness. To recast this argument in Joseph Roach’s terms: the child presented an exceptionally capacious *effigy* through which to *surrogate*, or perform, passionlessness.³⁹ I am arguing not that children made better women than women did—nor that women made better children than children did—but rather that women, girls, and boys, as effigies, or bodies in performance, possessed different abilities to surrogate, or perform, the elements of domesticity—including “purity” or “passionlessness.” One might think about the fit between actor and performance in terms of theatrical casting. Different actors might produce differently compelling performances within a single role. For example, in a contemporary stage performance of *The Wizard of Oz*, a director might consider casting in the role of Dorothy a young girl, a legibly gay man, or Diana Ross. Each one of these actors’ bodies, these performing effigies, possesses a special capacity for bringing forth a particular aspect of the story and the role: a young girl might ratify and naturalize the play as a “children’s classic”; an identifiably gay man might both nod to and burlesque the film’s significance to gay history; or Diana Ross might prompt audiences to view *The Wizard of Oz* through the lens of *The Wiz* (and not, for once, vice versa) and might therefore make visible the whiteness that was unmarked in the original Oz books, plays, and films. Each of these casting decisions is differently compelling and productive; none of the choices is “correct” or “incorrect.” Similarly, a mid-nineteenth-century woman, prepubescent girl, and prepubescent boy each possessed different abilities in varying performances of purity or passionlessness. A woman might assert the possibility of maintaining passionlessness within a marriage, and therefore in close proximity to a man’s passions and in coexistence with sexual acts. A girl might naturalize

feminine passionlessness most seamlessly. For boys, the performance of femininity was, paradoxically, useful to the construction of masculinity. Claudia Nelson argues that through “novelistic mechanisms[,] the ideals of womanliness were presented to Victorian boys as the ideals of manliness.”⁴⁰ In other words, Victorian boys surrogated femininity as part of a historicized process of becoming manly. It is not the case, then, that girls made better women than women did, but rather that women, girls, and boys presented differently credible and differently useful vehicles for the performance of sexual innocence.

Where Welter sees purity and Cott sees passionlessness, I see innocence—an active state of purity that is manifested through embodied performances of passionlessness. Sexual innocence is not a state of absence (asexuality or presexuality) but is instead a state of deflection: a constantly replenishing obliviousness that causes sexual matters to slide by without sticking. As I argued in my Introduction, the nineteenth-century white child—boy or girl—possessed a special ability to appear to repel markings of gender, class, or sexuality. Little Eva’s father, Augustine St. Clare, describes his daughter’s innocence as deflection rather than absence when he notes that “evil rolls off Eva’s mind like dew off a cabbage-leaf,—not a drop sinks in.”⁴¹ Because Eva’s skills in deflection maintain her purity, she may mingle with Topsy without danger of becoming corrupted—sexually *or* racially. That is, Eva is not only sexually innocent but also racially innocent. Racial innocence is a form of deflection, a not-knowing or obliviousness that can be made politically useful. It is racial innocence that might make the Cottolene girl’s viewer see her adorableness and notice her labor only later, if at all. Sexual innocence was a fundamental aspect of both the cult of true womanhood and sentimental childhood.⁴² Contra Gorham, the cult of domesticity did not invent children as the ultimate women, nor women as hyperbolic children. Rather, the cult of domesticity demanded performances of sexual innocence within the home. Women and children—girls especially, but also boys—supplied these performances differently, at different times, and with different strengths.

Racial innocence, as much as sexual innocence, was fundamental to the cult of domesticity. Hazel Carby and Ann DuCille argue persuasively that the cult of true womanhood was an inherently racial political project. In Carby’s view, the cult of true womanhood posited white women alone as sexually pure; the cult united white women across differences of class by excluding black women from purity and therefore from the category of womanhood.⁴³ DuCille takes up Nancy Cott’s argument that the concept

of passionlessness empowered white women. As Cott notes, “The ideology of passionlessness favored women’s power and self-respect” by “elevat[ing] women above the weakness of animal nature” and “allowing more intellectual breadth.”⁴⁴ In DuCille’s view, passionlessness was especially useful to black women writers, “whom the dominant culture continued to construct as inherently licentious and ‘always already sexual.’” For black women novelists of the 1890s, the ideology of passionlessness “negated a negative”; that is, it constituted a form of resistance rather than capitulation to middle-class values.⁴⁵ Together, Carby and DuCille suggest that sexual innocence, as an ideal for white women, excluded black women who were defined as sexual (or even hypersexual), and that black women’s reclamation of sexual innocence should be viewed as resistance.

Innocent childhood resembled the cult of true womanhood in that each discourse attached sexual innocence to white children and women, respectively. Antebellum black children, like black women, were assumed to be ineligible for sexual purity: as Mary Niall Mitchell notes, the sale of enslaved prepubescent girls calculated “their sexuality, or at the very least their anticipated fertility,” into their pricing.⁴⁶ During and after the Civil War, stage Topsyies performed what Elizabeth Young calls “excessive female sexuality” and “promiscuous heterosexuality.”⁴⁷ And this figure of Topsy, as Mitchell shows, suffused and clouded white people’s visions of freed African American girls: white teachers of African American children often described their female pupils as “Topsyies,” and when a *New York Times* correspondent visited Port Royal in 1862, he reported seeing “curly-headed picaninnies” and a “swarm of happy Topseys [*sic*]!”⁴⁸ Enslavement and the construction of Topsy-like slatterns excluded African American girls, along with their mothers, from the realm of passionlessness and the empowerment that passionlessness could confer.⁴⁹

Sexual innocence, then, divided white and black children in much the same way it did white and black women. Unique to the polarization of black and white children, however, was the libel, which emerged in the second half of the nineteenth century, that black juveniles did not—could not, even—experience pain. As Anna Mae Duane has argued persuasively, “vulnerability, suffering, and victimhood” defined nineteenth-century American childhood.⁵⁰ The libel that African American juveniles were invulnerable, did not suffer, and were not victims, then, defined them out of childhood itself.

Pain and Black Childhood through the Mid-Nineteenth Century

When the concept of angelic childhood innocence first coalesced, it did not necessarily exclude children of color. Romantic poets, including William Blake, allowed black children—especially boys—into the garden of natural childhood. “The Little Black Boy,” a very complex poem that Blake included among his *Songs of Innocence*, describes black and white children, at least on one level, as similar beneath their differences: “I am black, but O! my soul is white,” declares the narrator.⁵¹ Early abolitionist literature often connected innocence to the pain of slaves. For example, the anonymously authored poem “Negro Boy,” published in the 1821 *Poems: Moral and Religious, for Children and Youth*, deployed the figure of an innocent Negro child to expose the outrage of slavery. In this poem (which may have been influenced by Blake’s “The Little Black Boy”), the child narrator mourns his previous life in Africa, where he remembers being his “parents’ joy” and their “darling Negro boy.”⁵² Enslavement decimates this ideal childhood: the child narrator must now “labour day by day,” which causes sleepless nights of “pain.”⁵³ Even under slavery’s oppression, however, this child remains childlike: he misses his mother, and her absence pains him as much as his physical oppression does. “No mother’s ear” can hear his “groans,” so he is “cold and lonely”—a three-word phrase that conjoins physical and psychic pain.⁵⁴ The poem suggests, then, that slavery can assault but ultimately cannot eradicate this “darling” Negro boy’s childlike nature: the narrator continues to miss his mother. Furthermore, the narrator remains certain that “Good Heav’n” will someday “receive the Negro boy.”⁵⁵ For this poem’s anonymous author, black children are children; they love and are loved by their parents; they experience physical and emotional pain; they can enter Heaven; and these facts are all evidence in a political argument against slavery.⁵⁶

The narrator of “Negro Boy” experiences slavery, as would any child of any race, in relation to his family; thus the poem’s author suggests an essential commonality between black and nonblack children. At the mid-nineteenth century, however, as romanticism sugared over into sentimentalism, writers began to polarize black and white childhood—a configuration that largely disappeared nonblack children of color.⁵⁷ *Uncle Tom’s Cabin* crystallized the polarization of white and black childhood in this often-quoted description of Eva and Topsy:

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There stood the two children, representatives of the two extremes of society. The fair, high-bred child, with her golden head, her deep eyes, her spiritual, noble brow, and prince-like movements; and her black, keen, subtle, cringing, yet acute neighbor. They stood the representatives of their races. The Saxon, born of ages of cultivation, command, education, physical and moral eminence; the Afric, born of ages of oppression, submission, ignorance, toil, and vice!⁵⁸

Many scholars view Stowe's Topsy as a minstrel-influenced caricature, an essentialized manifestation of Stowe's white supremacy.⁵⁹ These scholars are not wrong. However, Topsy's minstrel antics coexist with Stowe's powerful paeans to the enslaved girl's essential childhood innocence. In the passage cited above, for example, Stowe casts the differences between Eva and Topsy as biologically embedded but ultimately not entirely essential: the "two children," as "representatives of their races," are the respective products of "ages of cultivation" and "ages of oppression." Eva owes her "deep eyes" and "noble brow" to generations that were "high-bred," while Topsy's body results from generations of "ignorance" and "vice." Thus Stowe argues in the mode of monogenesis, the view that all people descend from a common ancestor and that racial differences stem from environment (particularly climate and "civilized" society or lack thereof); and she rejects polygenesis, the belief, embraced by many of Stowe's contemporaries, that different races are of different species.⁶⁰ For Stowe, bodily habits layer over Topsy's and Eva's inherited racial traits: Eva's "prince-like movements" contrast with Topsy's "cringing" posture. Inherited and learned differences, then, polarize Topsy and Eva—but these differences, Stowe suggests here, are more the bodily effects of culture than the cultural effects of biology. Topsy is therefore the site of some of the deepest contradictions in Stowe's novel and racial politics.

The life experiences of enslaved children especially fired Stowe's imagination. Topsy, whom Stowe viewed as a "representative of a large class of the children who are growing up under the institution of slavery," arrives at the St. Clare household hardened by past abuse.⁶¹ This hardening renders the girl thinglike: before Topsy's conversion, Stowe describes Topsy as a "statue" and emphasizes the character's hardness in her doll-like "glassy eyes."⁶² Ophelia echoes this objectification when she calls Topsy a "thing."⁶³ Topsy often declares that she feels no pain (Ophelia's whippings "wouldn't kill a skeeter," Topsy taunts⁶⁴), but Stowe carefully shows that the opposite is true. Not only does Topsy feel pain, but it is her agonized screams that

initially bring St. Clare to the restaurant in which Topsy works, where the owners of the restaurant beat and swear at Topsy every day.⁶⁵ St. Clare buys Topsy in part because he is disturbed by her screams and wants to end her abuse—that is, the expression of her pain provokes his empathy and desire to intervene. Topsy’s hurt-ability is confirmed when Ophelia undresses the “neglected, abused child” and discovers that the “back and shoulders of the child” are marked with “great welts and calloused spots, ineffaceable marks of the system under which she had grown up.”⁶⁶ The enslaved child’s body is scarred, but even worse, her soul is “burnt . . . by the branding iron of cruel and unchristian scorn, that is a sorer and deeper wound than all the physical evils of slavery altogether.”⁶⁷ For Stowe, then, Topsy is not only *a* child, but, as Richard Brodhead has argued, she is “*the* child”—that is, a “paradigmatic case” of the physically hurt sentimental child.⁶⁸

Stowe confirms Topsy’s essential childhood through a social “experiment” that St. Clare sets up when he gives Topsy to his cousin, Ophelia.⁶⁹ In St. Clare’s view, the system of slavery “harden[s]” both slaves and slaveholders; the system causes “sensibilities to decline” among all people involved in slavery.⁷⁰ Once such desensitization occurs, an enslaved person may become governable “only by the lash”—and when the hardening becomes so thorough and the person so insensate that even the lash has no effect (“a very common state of things down here,” St. Clare interjects), “how are they to be governed?”⁷¹

“It is your system makes such children,” says Ophelia.⁷² St. Clare’s reply echoes and thus ratifies the constructed, nonessential nature of hardened slaves: “I know it; but they are *made*,—they exist,—and what is to be done with them?”

“Well,” Ophelia replies, “I can’t say I thank you for the experiment.”⁷³

In St. Clare’s “experiment,” then, Topsy tests whether a person “made” hard by the system of slavery can be returned to sensibility—that is, whether the essential child within Topsy is recoverable. Stowe argues that Topsy can be healed, but only through Eva’s moral, loving influence—what Richard Brodhead calls “disciplinary intimacy.” Stowe builds incrementally toward the touch that restores Topsy to humanity, natural Christianity, and childhood. At first, Eva speaks kindly to Topsy but does not touch her. In this scene, Eva pleads with Topsy not to steal, and offers to “give you anything of mine, [rather] than have you steal it.”⁷⁴ Eva’s are the

first word[s] of kindness the child [Topsy] had ever heard in her life; and the sweet tone and manner struck strangely on the wild, rude heart, and

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Figure 1.3. Tailpiece illustration by Hammatt Billings for *Uncle Tom's Cabin; or, Life Among the Lowly*, by Harriet Beecher Stowe, illustrated edition (Boston: John P. Jewett, 1853). Eva touches Topsy and thus restores feeling in the hardened slave. Billings's illustration, like Stowe's text, emphasizes the contrast between Topsy and Eva while suggesting an underlying connection and even equivalence: Billings marks differences in the girls' skin color and dresses (Eva's floats ethereally while Topsy's is appropriate for work), but the girls are of roughly equal size. Neither girl's face is caricatured; of the two, Topsy's is the more individualized. This image, like Stowe's prose, argues for Topsy's fundamental humanity. Courtesy of the American Antiquarian Society.

a sparkle of something like a tear shone in the keen, round, glittering eye; but it was followed by a short laugh and habitual grin. No! the ear that has never heard anything but abuse is strangely incredulous of anything so heavenly as kindness.⁷⁵

Eva's tender words partially penetrate Topsy's hardened exterior and cause

“something *like* a tear” (emphasis added) to well in Topsy’s beadlike, “glittering eye.” At this point in the narrative, Topsy has not shed a true tear—sentimentalism’s supreme sign of empathy and therefore of humanity. Because her ear is hardened by verbal abuse, her eyes can respond to kindness only with not-quite tears. Topsy’s conversion occurs only when Eva combines words of love with gentle touch (figure 1.3):

“[Miss Ophelia] can’t bar me, ’cause I’m a nigger!—she’d’s soon have a toad touch her! There can’t nobody love niggers, and niggers can’t do nothin’! I don’t care,” said Topsy, beginning to whistle.

“O, Topsy, poor child, *I love you!*” said Eva, with a sudden burst of feeling, and *laying her little thin, white hand on Topsy’s shoulder*; “I love you, because you haven’t had any father, or mother, or friends;—because you’ve been a poor, abused child! I love you, and I want you to be good. . . .”

The round, keen eyes of the black child were overcast with tears;—large, bright drops rolled heavily down, one by one, and fell on the little white hand. Yes, in that moment, a ray of real belief, a ray of heavenly love, had penetrated the darkness of her heathen soul! She laid her head down between her knees, and wept and sobbed,—while the beautiful child, bending over her, looked like the picture of some bright angel stooping to reclaim a sinner.

“Poor Topsy!” said Eva, “don’t you know that Jesus loves all alike? . . . He will help you to be good; and you can go to Heaven at last, and be an angel forever, just as much as if you were white.”⁷⁶

In this passage, Stowe first emphasizes Topsy’s hardened character: upon calling herself a “nigger,” likening herself to a toad, and declaring herself unlovable, Topsy proclaims herself unhurt (“I don’t care”) and whistles. Only the touch of Eva’s “white hand” combined with declarations of love for Topsy as a “poor, abused child” transforms “the black child.” At that moment, a “ray of real belief, a ray of heavenly love” penetrates Topsy, and for the first time in the novel, she weeps. It is in this scene that Topsy is converted into sensation, into humanized childhood, and even, Eva promises, potential angelhood—“just as much as if you were white.”

The next scene demonstrates the success of Topsy’s conversion and links that conversion explicitly to innocence. Topsy picks flowers, a crime for which Marie, Eva’s mother, slaps Topsy and calls her a “good-for-nothing nigger.”⁷⁷ Because these words issue from Marie, a wholly unsympathetic

character, they invite the reader to believe the opposite. Topsy insists that she picked the flowers not out of mischief, but out of desire to decorate Eva's sickroom. Eva—and Stowe's ideal reader—recognizes the truth that Marie cannot: that Topsy is innocent of any crime; that “Topsy is different from what she used to be” and is “quite unlike” her former self.⁷⁸ By promising that “Topsy could become an angel,” Eva names the enslaved girl's conversion into Christian innocence and thus into sentimental childhood itself.⁷⁹ Stowe, too, acknowledges Topsy's new status as a childlike innocent: from the moment of Topsy's conversion, Stowe's references to Topsy's eyes as “glittering” and “glassy” disappear. Topsy, now a feeling figure of sentimental domesticity, cries frequently and sincerely. By the time Eva dies, Topsy's “callous indifference [is] gone.”⁸⁰ Stowe, through St. Clare, explicitly names Eva's touch as the reason for the positive outcome of the “experiment”: “if we want to give sight to the blind, we must be willing to do as Christ did,—call them to us, and *put our hands on them*.”⁸¹

Before the mid-nineteenth century, then, black juveniles such as the 1821 “Negro Boy” were not uncommonly associated with innocence and the ability to feel pain; thus romantic childhood included black youth. At midcentury, Stowe created in Topsy an extraordinarily sophisticated and powerful argument for enslaved children's essential innocence and their susceptibility to suffering; thus Stowe configured Topsy as not only *a* child but, as Brodhead argues, *the* child of sentimentalism. Even as Stowe accomplished this feat, however, she loaded Topsy with contradictions and internal schisms. Topsy may have been a—or the—“neglected, abused child,” but she was also a minstrel-infused comic darky. She screamed and scarred, but she constantly declared herself unhurt—and for many readers, her memorable protestations ultimately drowned out the counter-testifying evidence Stowe so carefully planted in the novel.

These contradictions rendered Topsy vulnerable to selective readings and re-presentations. A reader, illustrator, or stager of *Uncle Tom's Cabin* could—and often did, as we shall see—focus on Topsy's comic antics and her claims to feel no pain while editing out the screams that St. Clare heard and the wounds that Ophelia saw. Stowe's interpreters could remember the contrasts between Topsy and Eva while forgetting that for Stowe, the characters' differences overlaid fundamental connections. This pattern of editing reversed the resolution of St. Clare's experiment and with it, a sheaf of Stowe's arguments: that slavery hardens otherwise sensate people, that this hardening can be reversed, and that all this is true because black children are essentially children.

Insensate Pickaninnies

One of the first and most influential people to stage elements of *Uncle Tom's Cabin* selectively and thus alter Stowe's politics was George L. Aiken. In 1852, Aiken penned a stage play of *Uncle Tom's Cabin* for performance by the Howard family troupe of actors (Aiken was a cousin of the troupe's leading players). This play—a "Tom show," as the popular stagings of *Uncle Tom's Cabin* came to be known—maximized the minstrel aspects that Stowe had already embedded in Topsy. In Aiken's script, Topsy arrives in the St. Clare household without welts and calluses, without any history of abuse legible on her body.⁸² Asked to sing and dance, the actress Caroline Fox Howard, who first played Topsy, belted out a catchy tune that highlights the stage character's signature lines, "I was never born," and "I's so wicked" (see figure 4.14 in Chapter 4):

Oh! White-folks I was never born,
Aunt Sue raise me on de corn,
Send me errands night and morn,
Ching a ring a ring a ricked.

She used to knock me on de floor,
Den bang my head agin de door,
And tare my hair out by de core,
Oh! Cause I was so wicked.⁸³

This song merrily, blithely reverses Stowe's assertion of Topsy's pain—and the political argument based on that assertion. Stowe's Topsy reports that her former mistress "used to pull my har, and knock my head agin the door"; Howard's song quotes these lines but attributes the violence to a black caretaker, not a white slaveholder.⁸⁴ Aiken's Topsy responds to violence not by becoming physically and emotionally damaged, but by laughing and singing about her invulnerability. Stowe's Topsy falsely believes herself to be "never born" because the system of slavery has imposed ignorance and godlessness upon her, but Aiken's Topsy transforms "never born" into a catchphrase, an automatic laugh line emptied of meaning. Perhaps the most telling reversal occurs along the axis of the word "wicked." Stowe's Topsy initially believes herself to be wicked because she has been emotionally abused. After Topsy's conversion via Eva's touch, however, the word "wicked" in reference to Topsy disappears simply and suddenly from

Stowe's novel. After the conversion, none of Stowe's characters, including Topsy herself, ever again calls the enslaved girl wicked. In contrast, Aiken's Topsy calls herself wicked immediately *after* her conversion: in response to Eva's exhortation to be good, Aiken's Topsy, sobbing, promises, "I will try; but den, I's so wicked!"⁸⁵ Topsy's signature song, "I'se So Wicked," similarly declares Topsy immune to Eva's efforts at conversion: "'Tis Little Eva, kind and fair, / Says if I'se good I will go dere, / But den I tells her, I don't care, / Oh! ain't I very wicked?"⁸⁶ Sentimental childhood, as Anna Mae Duane has argued, is founded on the child's suffering as it invites the adult reader or viewer to weep with and for the child.⁸⁷ Aiken stages Topsy weeping at her conversion, but within this pathos, he plants the laugh line, "I's so wicked." Aiken's script, then, invites the audience to laugh while Topsy cries. This invitation turns sentimentalism itself topsy-turvy.

When the Howard-Aiken version of *Uncle Tom's Cabin* configured Topsy as invulnerable to pain and invited audiences to laugh at the sight of Topsy's tears, the show not only reversed Stowe's individual politics, but also counteracted one of abolitionism's most organized, long-standing, and successful arguments: that slaves feel pain, and that this ability to feel pain demonstrates African Americans' fitness for freedom. Slavery had been legitimized in part by widespread claims that African Americans were impervious to pain. Thomas Jefferson, for example, wrote in 1781 in *Notes on the State of Virginia* that Negroes' "griefs are transient."⁸⁸ Southern doctors claimed that people of African descent carried a hereditary disease called "dyaesthesia Aethiopsis," or an "obtuse sensibility of body" that supposedly rendered black people invulnerable to corporal punishment.⁸⁹

At stake in pain was not only justification for violence but also eligibility for citizenship and humanity. Visible pain, or what Lauren Berlant calls the "trumping power of suffering," established individuals' and groups' subjectivity—and therefore, Linda Williams adds, their "worth as citizens."⁹⁰ Elizabeth B. Clark has shown that abolitionists understood the libel of black insensateness to disqualify African Americans from what Elaine Scarry has called the world-making properties of pain. Abolitionists understood a century and a half before Scarry that "the story of *physical pain*" is "a story about the expansive nature of human *sentience*, the felt-fact of aliveness."⁹¹ The stakes of pain are nothing less than the stakes of sentience, of humanity itself. To combat the libel of black insensateness, abolitionists showcased the physical, emotional, and spiritual suffering of enslaved people. When abolitionists dramatized slaves' pain—indeed,

when sentimental writers such as Stowe provoked readers sympathetically to *feel* slaves' pain—they based an argument for human rights on the ability to suffer. The refutation of the libel of black insensateness was one of abolitionism's most effective strategies and greatest triumphs.

When abolitionists succeeded, at mid-century, in circulating a counterdiscourse of African American pain and therefore sentience and humanity, the libel of insensateness did not disappear, but instead took up new residence in the juvenile form of the pickaninny. As this book argues throughout, when a racial argument is effectively countered or even delegitimized in adult culture, the argument often flows stealthily into children's culture or performances involving children's bodies. So located, the argument appears racially innocent. This appearance of innocence provides a cover under which otherwise discredited racial ideology survives and continues, covertly, to influence culture.

Throughout the second half of the nineteenth century, Topsy constituted an especially powerful vehicle for the newly juvenilized libel of black insensateness. Stowe had configured Topsy within the larger abolitionist project of asserting and showcasing slaves' pain: for Stowe, pain, as a fundamental aspect of the system of slavery, hardened Topsy *because* she felt it. In other words, Stowe's Topsy unnaturally *became* unfeeling exactly because by nature she *could* feel. Topsy's conversion *back* into feeling, into sensation, into weeping, is, for Stowe, crucial to Topsy's fitness for freedom. (Similarly, in the 1821 poem "Negro Boy," the narrator's suffering at losing his family constitutes the core of an abolitionist argument.) Popular culture however, erased both Topsy's hardening through abuse and her conversion into sensation. The Topsy of popular culture was therefore permanently, essentially unfit for citizenship.⁹² It was this unfeeling Topsy—the one scripted by Aiken and performed by Caroline Fox Howard—that "flew," as Henry James put it, out of Stowe's context to devolve into the pickaninny.⁹³ The Howard-Aiken production toured the United States and England for over thirty years and attracted hundreds of imitations. During these years, the Howard-Aiken vision of Topsy became a fixture in popular culture. This Topsy spawned "fearful progeny" in the pickaninny, as Montgomery Gregory wrote in 1925 and as contemporary scholars Jayna Brown, Tavia Nyong'o, and Patricia A. Turner have recently affirmed.⁹⁴ The inability to feel pain is the thread of DNA that connected the Howard-Aiken Topsy to all pickaninnies.

A series of advertisements that ran in the juvenile magazine the *Youth's Companion* from October 1893 through December 1894 makes explicit the

slippage between Topsy and the pickaninny at the axis of unfelt violence. Arnold Print Works, a company in North Adams, Massachusetts, advertised a variety of printed cloth dolls, including animals, Little Red Riding Hood, and “Pickaninny.” In the eyes of the copywriter, the “Pickaninny” doll answered—and commodified—a national desire to commit violence against a representation of an African American child:

What child in America does not at some time want a cloth “Nigger” dollie—one that can be petted or thrown about without harm to the doll or anything that it comes in contact with[?] “Pickaninny” fills all the requirements most completely.⁹⁵

By October 1894, the Arnold Print Works revised the advertisement to list the doll under the name “Topsy” as well as “Pickaninny.”⁹⁶ Topsy may be interchangeable with the pickaninny, these advertisements suggested, but either is a “Nigger” that any (white) “child in America” naturally wants to pet or throw about. This advertisement thus exemplifies the merging of Topsy, the pickaninny, and dollness as varieties of racist denigration (the word “nigger”). These ideas and identities merge at the point of unhurtability: what makes this doll a pickaninny, a Topsy, a “nigger” is not only its color, but also, crucially, the fact that it can be “thrown without harm.” That is, it cannot be hurt. This invulnerability allows or even instructs a presumably white child to play violently with the doll. The copy suggests that every (white) child in America wants to abuse a black doll, and the virtue of this particular black doll is that it can endure that practice without shattering. The doll itself, in its materiality, is seen to invite its own abuse.⁹⁷

Unrestrained violence against representations of black juveniles was, by the turn of the twentieth century, normalized in American popular culture. In advertisements, stage plays, film, material culture, and children’s books such as E. W. Kemble’s *A Coon Alphabet*, pickaninnies were beaten, scalded, attacked by animals, neglected, and dismembered—all without significant suffering. The libel that black youth cannot feel pain appears with horrifying vividness in Booth Tarkington’s *Penrod*, which was the seventh-best-selling novel of 1914.⁹⁸ *Penrod*’s eponymous protagonist was seen to emblemize the white boy adolescent, but two other characters in the novel—Herman and Verman—emblemize, with equal force, the pickaninny. Herman and Verman are African American brothers who move into a ramshackle cottage not far from Penrod’s home (their older brother, Sherman, is dead—a loss that no one ever explains or mourns).

The brothers are young, but their ages are never specified. When Penrod meets the brothers, Herman shows off his right hand, which lacks a forefinger. Herman explains eagerly that he had invited Verman to chop off the finger, and so Verman, whose name likens him to a small, vicious animal, had happily obliged by “chop[ping] ’er right spang off up to de roots!”⁹⁹ “What *for*?” Penrod asks with justified astonishment. “Jes’ fo’ nothin’,” Herman replies. Penrod repeats his question, and again Herman replies that he did it for “Nothin’. I jes’ said it ’at way—an’ he jes’ chop ’er off!” The brothers “looked pleased and proud” of the mutilation.¹⁰⁰

Today, this episode is shocking, but in 1914, no critics remarked on the story’s allegations that dismemberment does not pain black children and that violence is a “nothing” that pickaninnies comically visit upon each other. Indeed, *Penrod* was perceived as a novel that reproduced the care-free innocence of boyhood: “The book is deliciously whimsical, clever, and filled with innocent fun,” commented one reviewer.¹⁰¹ If a review mentioned Herman and Verman, it typically did so in appreciation of the characters’ humorous antics. Violence against these child characters in no way diminished or polluted the pleasure they delivered to white consumers, as one reviewer of a stage adaptation acknowledged by calling Herman and Verman an “unalloyed delight.”¹⁰²

Penrod could be celebrated as “innocent fun” because by the time the novel was published, the pickaninny, defined by insensitivity to pain, was among the most common libels against African Americans. By the early twentieth century, manufacturers had slapped the image of the pickaninny on products including soap, postcards, sheet music, games, dolls, tobacco, matches, ashtrays, crackers, soda, menus, letter openers, figurines, brooches, farm produce, textiles of all sorts, and much, much more.¹⁰³ The repetitious ubiquity of the insensate pickaninny itself de-sensitized white readers and other consumers to African American pain. Throughout this proliferation of pickaninny images, Topsy remained a central figure in the libel that black children were physically invulnerable. In the 1933 animated short, “Mickey’s Mellerdrammer,” Walt Disney’s characters stage a production of *Uncle Tom’s Cabin*. Before the play begins, Mickey costumes himself as Topsy by donning a ragged sack and a wild wig, and then lighting a stick of dynamite in his mouth. The dynamite explodes and blackens Mickey’s face; the mouse grins at his dressing-room mirror, delighted with the explosion’s effect. Thus unfelt violence literally constitutes the blackness of Topsy—and, by implication, all her fearful progeny.¹⁰⁴

The concept of African American insensateness had existed in Jefferson’s

eighteenth century, but the pickaninny compressed the libel into the icon of a juvenile body. As a compact and instantly recognizable emblem of black insensateness, the pickaninny was uniquely useful in advertising, as we saw in the Cottolene trade card: the Cottolene girl appears to feel no pain or even discomfort in her labor, and this absence of pain configures the production of cotton, Cottolene's definitional ingredient, as innocent—a sharp contrast with Hine's photograph of Callie Campbell, which pictures a white girl's pain and thus critiques the use of child labor in the production of cotton. When laminated to commodities, the pickaninny, as that-which-cannot-be-hurt, masked the exploitative and even violent aspects of industrialization. Topsy's hardness, her insensateness, was, for Stowe, a constructed and pathological result—and therefore indictment—of the violence inherent in the system of slavery. But the pickaninny's essentialized insensateness *resolved* ethical problems of violence: viciousness against African American juveniles was not immoral if it did not hurt. Thus the pickaninny transformed Stowe's critique of racist violence into an apology for it.

This history of Topsy's polarity with Eva, of Topsy as the pickaninny's progenitor, and of the politics of insensateness explains not only how the trade card sold Cottolene but also how Hine's photograph protested child labor through the dynamic of defamiliarization. Many scholars have gestured toward Hine's use of defamiliarization when they have noted that Hine photographed children's bodies where an adult body was expected: Hine showed children dwarfed by machines, and this juxtaposition asserted a mismatch between children and labor.¹⁰⁵ We see this well-known dynamic in figure 1.2 in the disproportion between Callie Campbell and her sack, which makes a visual case against so small a child bearing so great a burden.¹⁰⁶ Hine also employed, however, a second and heretofore unacknowledged mode of defamiliarization: in this photograph and many others, Hine substituted not only a child for an adult, but also a white child for an African American of any age. In the era of Jim Crow, the naturalized body picking cotton was black. By the time Hine photographed Callie Campbell, U.S. popular culture had swelled for at least six decades with images of de-childed pickaninnies and childlike black adults picking cotton. From advertisements and book illustrations to sheet music and stage shows, images of happy African Americans laboring in the fields justified and naturalized slavery and later sharecropping. The Hine photograph interrupted this field of vision when it placed a white child, topsy-turvy, where a black child (or adult) was expected.¹⁰⁷ Callie

Campbell's white innocence, her essential childhood that her labor threatened and that Hine's photograph asked its viewer to protect, depended on the logic of the pickaninny, on the evacuation of innocence from African American children.

The pickaninny, as a de-childed juvenile, ultimately reserved infancy for black adults. The libelous, de-childed pickaninny was interdependent with the libel of the "childlike Negro."¹⁰⁸ At stake in the refutation of the pickaninny image was not only black childhood but also black adulthood. African Americans, both adults and children, widely understood what was at stake in the insensate pickaninny, and they resisted.

"SLAVE-children are children"

When U.S. culture began, at mid-century, to libel black children as unhurttable and unchildlike, African Americans—both children and adults—began asserting that black children were, of course, children and did, of course, feel pain. In 1863, for example, in Corinth, Mississippi, an African American girl named Nell fought back against white adults who insisted on likening her to the insensate, minstrelized vision of Topsy. Nell's teacher claimed that the girl "testifie[d] to the genuineness and reality" in Stowe's "portrait of 'Topsy.'" When the teacher "dressed her up and kept her about to do little errands" and to "sing, dance, and act quite as comically as Topsy ever did," she cast Nell in a performance of Topsy.¹⁰⁹ Costuming, singing, dancing, and comedy are all important to the performance of Topsy, but the core element, as I have argued, is unfelt violence. A clerk attempted to impose this element on Nell when he "got in the habit of tapping [Nell] upon the head . . . just to see her roll up her eyes at me" in a "comically-deprecating" gesture of minstrelsy. The clerk said that he "tapped her pretty hard sometimes" on the head because it amused him to do so, and because he believed that "Her wool is thick" and that therefore he could "rely . . . upon its softness to protect her." That is, the clerk read Nell's racial markings as evidence that his "tapp[ing] her pretty hard" could not hurt her.

Of course, Nell was no minstrel darky, and the clerk's blows did pain her. The girl found a way to protect herself: she tucked an ounce of pins into her hair with the points out. The clerk soon "tapped" her as usual, "so hard as to get a dozen [pins] right through [his] hand," which became "covered with blood."¹¹⁰ Nell's action was practical and immediately effective, certainly, but it also intervened brilliantly (although probably not

consciously) on a textual level. Nell's teacher and the clerk together configured the girl as an unhurttable Topsy, a comic pickaninny rather than a human child. Nell's strategy was not simply one of self-protection, which she could have enacted by tucking padding rather than pins into her hair. Nor did Nell reach simply for revenge—quite unlike Stowe's preconversion Topsy, who often arranged for “some inconvenient accident” such as a “libation of dirty slop” to fall on anyone who “cast an indignity” upon her.¹¹¹ In lieu of simple self-protection or revenge, Nell caused reciprocal pain to penetrate the clerk at the precise moment of his blow. She caused the clerk's blow to hurt *him*. Thus Nell simultaneously restored and signified on the sentimental sympathy that stage Topsies had evacuated from black childhood. She forced the clerk to feel her pain; she made him, in Stowe's famous phrase, “feel right.”¹¹²

African American adults, too, fought for recognition of black children's pain. Harriet Wilson, author of the 1859 novel *Our Nig; or, Sketches from the Life of a Free Black*, reimagined *Uncle Tom's Cabin* toward this end. *Our Nig* tells the story of Frado, the free daughter of a white mother and black father in the North, who is forced to labor for the vicious Mrs. Bellmont and her family. Mrs. Bellmont and her daughter Mary torture Frado physically and emotionally, as the novel describes with agonizing specificity. In several especially brutal scenes, Mrs. Bellmont wedges Frado's mouth open with a block of wood or a towel, thus silencing the girl while the woman beats her. Carla Peterson, Elizabeth Ammons, and other scholars have identified parallels and inversions between *Our Nig* and *Uncle Tom's Cabin* that suggest that Wilson was familiar with Stowe's novel, that it influenced her, and that she may have envisioned her novel as a partial response to Stowe's.¹¹³ Ammons, for example, maps “mirror imaging” between Stowe's Marie St. Clare and Wilson's Mrs. Bellmont, between Little Eva and James (Bellmont's saintly son who tries to protect Frado and who ultimately dies), and between Tom and Frado.¹¹⁴ Two characters, however, are notably absent from Ammons's pairings: Stowe's Topsy and Wilson's Mary. These major characters, I argue, actually figure at the center of Wilson's rereading of—and attack on—Stowe.

Stowe's novel, we recall, argues that Topsy was naturally feeling, but that slavery hardened her, and that Topsy could be at least partially redeemed through the loving touch of an angelic white girl. Wilson's novel argues, in contrast, that the absence of African Americans' tears is a performance that white people impose and maintain, fully aware that the tearless African American face masks agony. Topsy's absence of tears

prior to conversion is, for Stowe, a *symptom* of white-on-black violence, but Frado's absence of tears is, for Wilson, a *mode* of white-on-black violence. Unlike the hardened Topsy, Frado does not stop crying because Mrs. Bellmont beats her; rather, Mrs. Bellmont and her daughter Mary beat Frado to force her to stop the spectacle of black pain. In scene after scene, Mrs. Bellmont whips Frado for the "act of disobedience" of having "wept aloud."¹¹⁵ For Frado, showing pain is a crime, so she endeavors "not to be seen . . . in tears."¹¹⁶ The excruciating scenes of gagging literalize Frado's enforced self-gagging in which she "choke[s]" her tears to evade further violence.¹¹⁷

By choking, gagging, and beating Frado, Mrs. Bellmont and Mary produce an appearance of black insensateness that even Mrs. Bellmont knows to be illusory: as Bellmont's son James notes, his mother "*pretends* to think she [Frado] don't know enough to sorrow for anything."¹¹⁸ Mrs. Bellmont wants to see Frado as a pickaninny who is too stupid to sorrow, but Bellmont can only "pretend" to believe in the essentiality of the performance she coerced. Frado dons a tearless mask, an appearance, only, of the absence of feeling. The strain of withholding tears, of performing insensateness, becomes an integral part of the torture. By exposing this dynamic, Wilson brilliantly deconstructs the libel of black insensateness, showing it to be neither a symptom of black inferiority (as per proslavery writers) nor a pathological response to violence (as per Stowe), but rather a black performance that white people coerce out of their own pathological desires simultaneously to cause pain and to deny that they are doing so.

In her defense of black childhood, Wilson singles out the white angel-child, especially as emblemized by Stowe's Eva, for trenchant attack. Stowe's Eva and Wilson's Mary occupy parallel places in the family structure: each is the daughter of the white couple that holds a black girl (either as a slave or an extralegally indentured servant). While Eva embraces Topsy through the act of converting the black girl, Mary locks into a grim embrace with Frado through the act of torturing her. James does, as Ammons notes, partially resurrect Eva in boy form, but Mary is Eva's evil twin, and Frado is Topsy's true redeemer.

Wilson begins her bold attack on the figure of the white angel-child in the novel's first paragraph. The novel opens with Mag, who is identified in the first chapter's title as "My Mother," giving birth to an illegitimate baby. The reader might reasonably suppose this baby—the daughter of "my mother"—to be the narrator, who is in that case telling the story of her own birth. By the end of the first paragraph, however, that expectation

is thwarted: the baby dies, and Mag, a ghoulish parody of what Elizabeth Ammons calls the sentimental “mother-savior,” exults. The deceased baby, the reader learns, is not the “Free Black” of the novel’s subtitle, but is instead a white baby—that most conventional sentimental sign of angelic innocence. However, this dead white baby girl is sin-stained, not heaven-bound. The white children of women such as Mag, the narrator comments, may “inherit a wicked heart of their own” that requires “life-long scrutiny and restraint.”¹¹⁹ The angelic qualities that Stowe might ascribe to the white baby, Wilson assigns ironically to Mag’s white seducer, whose voice “seemed like an angel’s.”¹²⁰ Wilson purges a dead, white baby girl of her expected angelic qualities and assigns the *illusion* of them to a rake who ventriloquizes an angel’s voice as a means by which to ruin Mag. These events, all of which occur within the novel’s first three hundred words, signal a narrative strategy of using racial flip-flops to decimate sentimental notions of childhood innocence. The baby whom the reader expected to become the “Free Black” narrator turns out to be a white infant; the dead white baby is no angel; and the only apparent angel deserves suspicion rather than reverence.

Later in the novel, Wilson uses racial flip-flops to skewer the white angel-child again, but even more forcefully: when the malevolent Mary Bellmont dies, Frado comments, “S’posen she goes to hell, she’ll be as black as I am.”¹²¹ To appreciate the full force of this extraordinary line, it is necessary to contextualize it within abolitionist conversations about white children, black children, and angels. As Elizabeth Clark has shown, white abolitionists argued tenaciously, and to great effect, that African Americans could and did feel pain. In the context of childhood, this assertion raised a question: if black youth could feel pain (because they were black, not because they were children), could they, like white children, complete the sequence of suffering, dying, and becoming angels? A few decades earlier, abolitionists such as the author of the 1821 poem “Negro Boy” readily answered “yes.” At midcentury, however, as white and black childhood began to split, this question acquired a nervous edge. Black and white childhood had begun differentiating from each other along the polarity of tender white angel/insensate black pickaninny, and to allow for black angels was to mix the poles and thus potentially to threaten the emerging nature of *white* sentimental childhood. At this moment, stories began to appear in which characters engaged in lengthy and often unresolved debates over whether black children who piously endured pain could become angels.

A representative example of this anxious debate appears in Lynde

Palmer's 1862 antislavery story "Poor Black Violet." The story accentuates the pain that Violet, an enslaved girl, feels as she hauls bricks: "Poor little Violet was much bruised, but she could not rest long, for the overseer called her name, and told her 'not to be lazy.' So she went slowly on as if in a dream, toiling painfully over the weary way."¹²² Even as the story affirms the abolitionist argument that slaves feel pain, however, the narrative dances nervously around the question of whether black children can enter heaven and become angels. In one very disturbing scene, Violet discusses death and angelhood with a white slaveholding girl named Carrie. Violet asks,

"[W]hen we goes to Canaan, that old Sambo sings about, may I be your little slave *then*, Miss Carrie, 'cause you's allus so kind?"

"I don't think there will be any slaves there," said Carrie, slowly, pondering over the matter.

"Why, what will the black people do, then?" cried Violet, with curious round eyes.

"Maybe," replied Carrie hesitatingly, "maybe there won't *be* any black people—you know, Violet, our bodies are covered up in the ground,"—Violet shivered,—“but our souls go to heaven, and they must all be white.”

"*All* of 'em?" asked Violet, eagerly.

"Yes, mamma told me that no soul can go till it is washed *white* in Jesus' blood."

"And can my *soul* be white?" whispered Violet.

"Yes," said Carrie, "if you ask God."¹²³

Soon after this dialogue, a poisonous snake attacks Carrie's brother Frank, who, earlier in the story, had threatened Violet and called her a nigger. Violet saves her tormentor from the snake, but in the process it bites her. As Violet dies, Carrie prays, "Please, Jesus, give Violet a white soul."¹²⁴ The story ends without resolving the question of whether Violet will enter heaven and become an angel, and the closing line calls attention to that absence of closure.

Frank shuddered violently as he thought of the terrible fate he had escaped, and his heart was full of remorse as he remembered his cruelty to the patient, forgiving little slave, who had been so much more noble than he. His father, with a heart full of thanksgiving for the life of his only son, looked tearfully upon the motionless little form, and said, tenderly,—“Poor little

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black Violet!” And Carrie, sobbing bitterly, forgetful of the new white soul, echoed,—“Poor little black Violet!” But no one knew what the angels said.¹²⁵

Wilson, writing in 1859, could not have read Palmer’s 1862 story, but she was clearly aware of abolitionist writing and culture, including but not limited to *Uncle Tom’s Cabin*, in which Palmer’s story was located.¹²⁶ And she certainly seems to have been aware of white abolitionists’ tedious and condescending conversations about whether black children could become angel-children, and if so, whether they would have to become white first. Stowe might have considered herself quite the racial progressive when she wrote Eva’s line reassuring Topsy that the black girl “can go to Heaven at last, and be an angel forever, just as much as if you were white.”¹²⁷ But Wilson turns the entire debate topsy-turvy. Against Stowe’s and Palmer’s simpering characters who long for heaven, Frado turns her thoughts toward hell. If Mary “goes to hell,” Frado declares fearlessly, “she’ll be as black as I am.” Frado follows immediately with an even more shocking coda: “Would n’t mistress be mad to see her a nigger!”¹²⁸ With this ugly racial flip-flop, the shocking image of a white girl—Little Eva’s structural parallel in the Bellmont family—going to hell, turning black, and being *seen*, spectacularly, by her own mother as a “nigger,” is an attack on the midcentury’s most cherished ideologies of white childhood. Wilson, through Frado, tells the entire abolitionist debate over angel-children to go to hell. With this malediction, Wilson attacks nothing less than the racial innocence that was, in 1859, rapidly becoming the new foundation of white childhood.

Whereas Harriet Wilson asserted a black child’s pain as a means by which to damn white childhood, Frederick Douglass took a different tack. In *My Bondage and My Freedom*, Douglass asserted, in the most explicit language and typographic emphasis available, “SLAVE-children *are* children.”¹²⁹ Douglass, like Wilson, coupled his defense of African American children as children and as sensate with an attack on the foundations of white childhood. Wilson targeted the white angel-child as a major figure of sentimentalism, but Douglass uprooted sentimental childhood itself and planted black boys—including and especially himself—in the landscape of romantic childhood.¹³⁰ Douglass, like Wilson, tucked his assertion that enslaved children are children within descriptions of black children’s vulnerability and pain—in this case, emotional pain:

Children have their sorrows as well as men and women; and it would be well to remember this in our dealings with them. SLAVE-children *are* children,

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and prove no exception to the general rule. The liability to be separated from my grandmother, seldom or never to see her again, haunted me. . . . I look back to this as among the heaviest of my childhood's sorrows.¹³¹

Douglass's argument that black children are children suspends between and depends on his assertions of black children's sorrows. However, Douglass hastens in the next paragraph to add that it "is not even within the power of slavery to write *indelible* sorrow, at a single dash, over the heart of a child."¹³² Douglass, like Stowe, suggests that no amount of abuse can obliterate an enslaved child's essential childhood. Stowe argues that black and white childhoods are connected even as they polarize; her Topsy and Eva are both inversions of each other and quasi-siblings (and later, when Ophelia adopts Topsy, and after Eva dies, the girls posthumously become second cousins).¹³³ Although Eva and Topsy do not share paternity, Stowe raises through them the specter of black and white children being literal half siblings. Douglass makes this point more explicitly and infinitely more trenchantly: "The first seven or eight years of the slave-boy's life," Douglass tells his reader, "are about as full of sweet content as those of the most favored and petted *white* children of the slaveholder."¹³⁴ By italicizing the word *white*, Douglass implies the possibility of other, nonwhite children of the slaveholder. The next sentence asserts not the possibility but the reality of differently raced siblings coexisting: "The slave-boy," Douglass writes, "escapes many troubles which befall and vex his white brother."¹³⁵

The troubles that befall the slaveholder's *white* children are those of the overcivilized, feminized boy who is forced to "act like a nice little gentleman" or "swallow pretty little sugar-coated pills, to cleanse his blood, or to quicken his appetite."¹³⁶ This nice, sugary, appetite-less boy is the passionless child of sentimentalism. Douglass ridicules this child and embraces instead his rugged, romantic ancestor. It would be wrong to say that Douglass resurrected romantic childhood, because it never went away (indeed, traces of it remain today in summer camps and other cultural structures that suggest that no childhood is complete without contact with the wilderness). Romanticism, we recall, had long included black children, and especially black boys. What is new in Douglass's autobiography, however, is his use of romantic childhood to argue that black boys make *better* boys than their white brothers do. Douglass accomplishes this feat in one massive paragraph which, in the book's original edition, spanned three full pages. The enslaved boy, writes Douglass,

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seldom has to listen to lectures on propriety of behavior, or on anything else. . . . He never has the misfortune, in his games or sports, of soiling or tearing his clothes, for he has almost none to soil or tear. He is never expected to act like a nice little gentleman, for he is only a rude little slave. Thus, freed from all restraint, the slave-boy can be, in his life and conduct, a genuine boy, doing whatever his boyish nature suggests. . . . He literally runs wild; has no pretty little verses to learn in the nursery; no nice little speeches to make for aunts, uncles, or cousins, to show how smart he is. . . . [O]ur sable boy continues to roll in the dust, or play in the mud, as bests [*sic*] suits him, and in the veriest freedom. If he feels uncomfortable, from mud or from dust, the coast is clear; he can plunge into the river or the pond, without the ceremony of undressing, or the fear of wetting his clothes. . . . His days, when the weather is warm, are spent in the pure, open air, and in the bright sunshine. He always sleeps in airy apartments; he seldom has to take powders, or to be paid to swallow pretty little sugar-coated pills, to cleanse his blood, or to quicken his appetite. . . . In a word, he is, for the most part of the first eight years of his life, a spirited, joyous, uproarious, and happy boy, upon whom troubles fall only like water on a duck's back. And such a boy, so far as I can now remember, was the boy whose life in slavery I am now narrating.¹³⁷

Slavery, this passage argues, paradoxically frees a slave-boy to be “a genuine boy” who runs unfettered in nature, breathing clean air, sporting without fear of dirt, or plunging into a swimming hole. The enslaved boy, Douglass argues, is not only *a* boy but *the* ideal boy—not of sentimentalism, but of romanticism. Unlike the slaveholder's *white* son, who needs medicine to achieve a normal appetite, the enslaved child is “a spirited, joyous, uproarious, and happy boy.” Douglass's reclamation of romantic childhood, over and above sentimental childhood, marks a critical intersection of gender with race and age.

Abolitionists sometimes struggled to include suffering black girls such as Topsy or Violet within sentimental childhood, often with internally contradictory or ambiguous results; but white writers' efforts to envision black boys as sentimental children were extremely rare and even more awkward. This failure of imagination registers, for example, in Harry Harris, the son of Eliza and George Harris in *Uncle Tom's Cabin* (and many scholars agree that Douglass both mirrored and refuted Harry in *My Bondage and My Freedom*).¹³⁸ Harry appears at Stowe's novel's outset, where he answers to the name of “Jim Crow” and performs, upon request,

“a wild, grotesque song” and “scamper[s]” after raisins that the slaveholding Shelby scatters on the floor.¹³⁹ Harry’s beauty and minstrel skills motivate the slave trader Haley to buy the boy. Eliza learns of the sale and flees with Harry—an action that launches the rest of the novel’s plot. After Stowe locates Harry at the heart of her novel, however, she demotes him from a full-fledged if minstrelized character to a plot device. Harry, who seems so full of vigor and talent in the opening scene, never again says or does anything individuated or interesting, never again exerts anything resembling agency. His main actions, for the rest of the novel, are to be fed seedcakes, to be petted as characters exclaim over his glossy curls, and to sleep. He is something beloved to look at and protect, a feminized object who passively accepts being cross-dressed as a girl during one portion of the escape. No wonder that in Tom shows, Harry was often played by a doll in Eliza’s arms.¹⁴⁰

Douglass rejected such constructions of African American childhood by banishing *girls*, as well as feminine sentimental boys, from his vision of ideal childhood. Douglass shows little interest in a black boy like Harry who performs piety, purity, submissiveness, and domesticity—even as an element, as Claudia Nelson suggests, of sentimental manliness. He does not demand space within sentimentalism for a beautiful black boy like Harry who “makes” a “pretty girl.”¹⁴¹ Instead, Douglass rejects sentimentalism in favor of a masculinist romanticism. In this landscape, the enslaved boy becomes not a timid or grateful visitor to the realm of childhood, but instead its worthiest citizen. “And such a boy,” Douglass tells the reader pointedly, is none other than “the boy whose life in slavery I am now narrating”—that is, Douglass himself, not a boy, but a man. At stake in black childhood, Douglass well understood, is black adulthood, black manhood—for the black boy is the father of the black man.

Different Trajectories, Different Destinations

Different trajectories of white and black childhood during the second half of the nineteenth century resulted, by the turn of the twentieth, in sharply bifurcated visions of American childhood. In the second half of the nineteenth century, white childhood, and especially white girlhood, became laminated to the idea of innocence; to invoke white childhood was to invoke innocence itself. In contrast, images of nonsuffering black pickaninnies emptied black childhood of innocence. Even when a pickaninny was



Figure 1.4. A white girl advertises Cottolene, a lard substitute. Trade card for Cottolene, manufactured by N. K. Fairbank and Company, Chicago, circa 1890s. Collection of the author.

well-dressed and adorable, as in the Cottolene advertisement that opened this chapter, this icon of insensateness did not call for protection. Whereas the white child manifested innocence, the pickaninny deflected it: the pickaninny made not itself, but its violent context, appear innocent. Carefree innocence suffused Penrod, that icon of white boyhood; but what was innocent about the mutilated Herman was not himself, but the unfelt violence against him. Hine's photograph of an innocent white girl called on the viewer to protect its subject by opposing child labor, whereas the pain-free figure in the Cottolene card made child labor and its product—cotton—seem innocuous, naturalized, and beyond criticism. The bifurcation of childhood innocence, through pain and its alleged absence, imbued racial innocence—that is, the pivotal use of childhood innocence in racial politics—with an uncanny flexibility and therefore the power to support opposing agendas.

The divergence between black and white childhood by the end of the nineteenth century can ultimately be measured and marked in the contrast between the Cottolene card depicting a black girl and a second one, also of the 1890s, which features a white girl with long blond hair (figure 1.4 and plate 2). The black Cottolene girl presents her tender puff of cotton as she might a baby. This gesture of showing in fact hides and mystifies the means of cotton production by making the Cottolene girl's labor seem innocent. The black Cottolene girl labors, shows, and hides; the white Cottolene girl, in contrast, is not shown in the midst of any action: she is neither producing an ingredient for, cooking with, nor consuming food containing Cottolene. She only hovers, cloud-like, with a facial expression of passive contentment. This white girl exists as a decoration—an emblem, perhaps, of Cottolene's white color, or of the product's "Purity!," as the trade card's verso exclaims. If the black Cottolene girl is Topsy's "fearful progeny," the white Cottolene girl is Eva's. She is the pure, white angel-child whom popular culture retained long after sentimentalism lost currency (and who still lingers, today, in the tender faces of blond girls from Shirley Temple to Jon-Benet Ramsay to Dakota Fanning). Defined, always, in relation to this white angel-child, the black Cottolene girl painlessly labors so the white angel might rest placidly. In contrast to both the naturally cotton-picking pickaninny and the white angel-child, Callie Campbell seems like an angel with unjustly clipped wings. And a cloud-like puff of white cotton seems to deserve the tender care that the black girl who tirelessly picks it for Cottolene never needs.

One final image measures the distance traveled—and not—between the mid-nineteenth century and the early twentieth. In 1908, Reilly and Britton, publisher of L. Frank Baum's Oz series, produced a volume that contained both Helen Bannerman's *The Story of Little Black Sambo* and an anonymously authored revision of *Uncle Tom's Cabin* titled "The Story of Topsy." John R. Neill, Baum's most famous illustrator, signed the illustrations for *Little Black Sambo*, and there is no reason to doubt that he also illustrated Topsy's story.¹⁴² One of the illustrations (figure 1.5 and plate 3) accompanies the scene in which Eva converts Topsy—the same scene that Hammatt Billings illustrated in 1853 (figure 1.3). The similarities and contrasts between the 1853 and 1908 illustrations track the divergent paths of the white angel-child and black pickaninny.

From Billings's 1853 to Neill's 1908, Eva has changed relatively little. In each image, the white girl shows her profile to the reader while her eyes focus on Topsy's face. The hand of each white girl touches the enslaved girl's shoulder. Eva's hair, in both images, is soft and light; her feet are slippered and small. Eva's dresses differ according to the fashion of the day, but both the 1853 and 1908 dresses puff, cloudlike, around her body. Each image provides a reference point to emphasize Eva's smallness: Billings juxtaposes his Eva with a large table and Neill burdens his Eva with an oversized hat and ribbon, each of which makes the white girl seem delicate, even vulnerable.

As these two images exemplify, the white angel-child was preserved, largely unchanged, from 1853 to 1908. The black child, however, changed mightily in the half-century separating Billings's image from Neill's. In 1853, Billings orients Topsy's body away from Eva, but he turns Topsy's head toward the little evangelist. The mixed orientation in the image suggests not only the possibility of change but the moment of literal turning. Billings's illustration, like Stowe's prose, asserts the possibility of Topsy awakening to sensation, and thus argues for Topsy's essential humanity. In 1908, Neill burlesques this possibility: his Eva, too, touches Topsy, who faces Eva squarely and with full attention, but there is no hope that this cringing, muscular, big-footed, inhumanly lipped creature could ever be childlike, could ever be human. In Stowe's prose that pairs with Billings's illustration, Eva's touch makes Topsy feel and weep. In contrast, Neill's Topsy, upon receiving Eva's touch and kind words, "could only blink and rub her eyes."¹⁴³ The Topsy of Stowe and Billings converts to Christianity and eventually becomes a missionary. The Topsy that Neill pictures in the 1908 version, however, "soon learn[s] the ways of negroes of the



Figure 1.5. Unsigned illustration (most likely by John R. Neill) for “The Story of Topsy from *Uncle Tom’s Cabin*,” published in *Little Black Sambo*, by Helen Bannerman (Chicago: Reilly and Britton, 1908). Eva converts Topsy, who is depicted as a pickaninny with inhuman lips, oversized feet, and unchildlike muscles. Courtesy of the Beinecke Rare Book and Manuscript Library, Yale University.

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better class” but remains essentially mischievous, engaging in boisterous play with pillows and bedclothes long after the conversion that convinced Stowe’s Topsy to be good.¹⁴⁴ When caught dressing a bolster in Ophelia’s nightgown, Neill’s Topsy asks to be whipped—much as *Penrod*’s Herman requests to be mutilated. At the dawn of the twentieth century, the perpetually dying Eva lingered, while Topsy, the damaged child, was overpowered, redefined, and replaced by her fearful spawn. Innocence had become the exclusive property of the vulnerable white child, while the pain-free pickaninny was exiled from innocence and with it, from childhood—and humanity.